Power Platform
COMMUNITY CONFERENCE

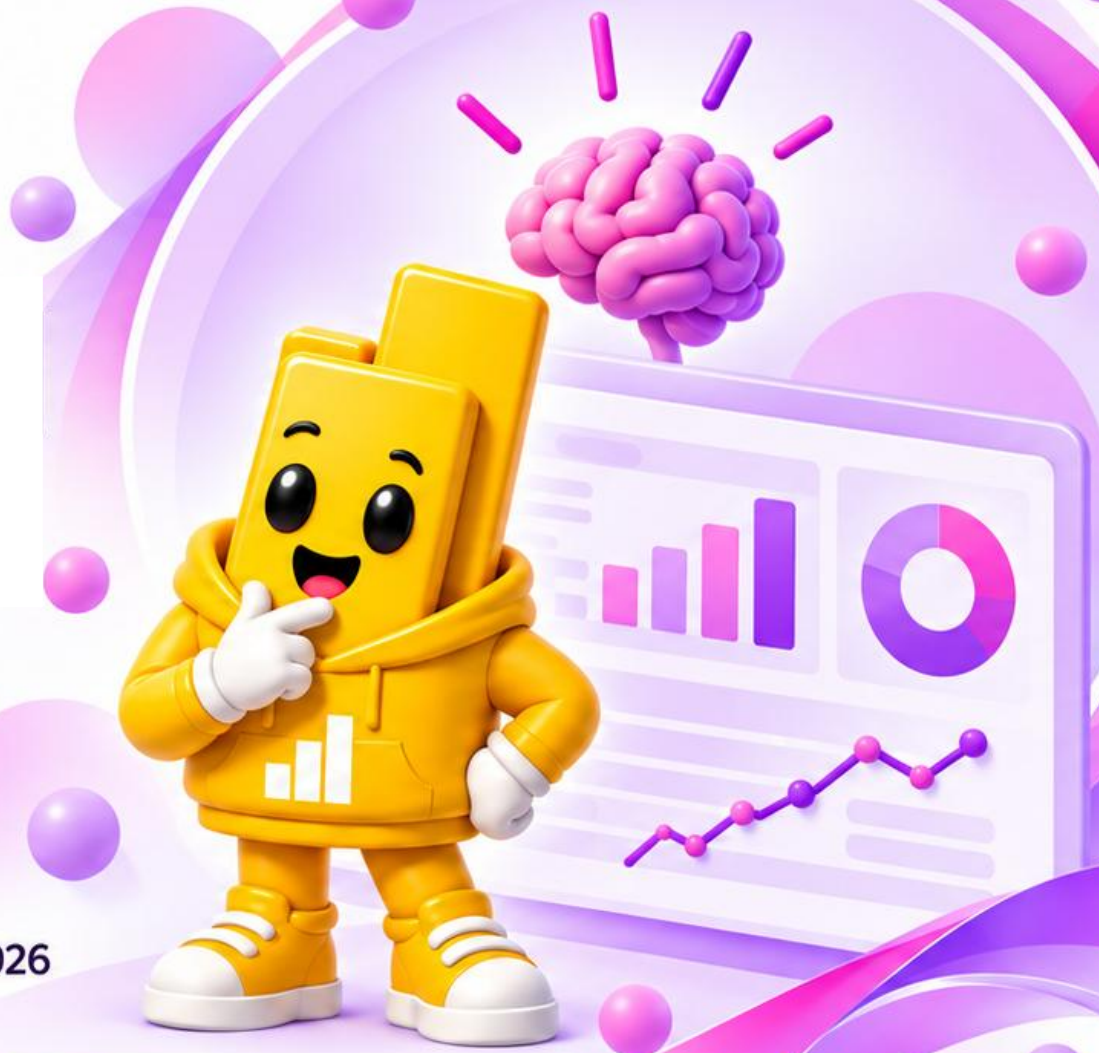
The Psychology Behind Powerful Power BI Reports



Lakshmi Ponnurasan

Power BI DataViz Championship Finalist 2025 & 2026

Microsoft MVP




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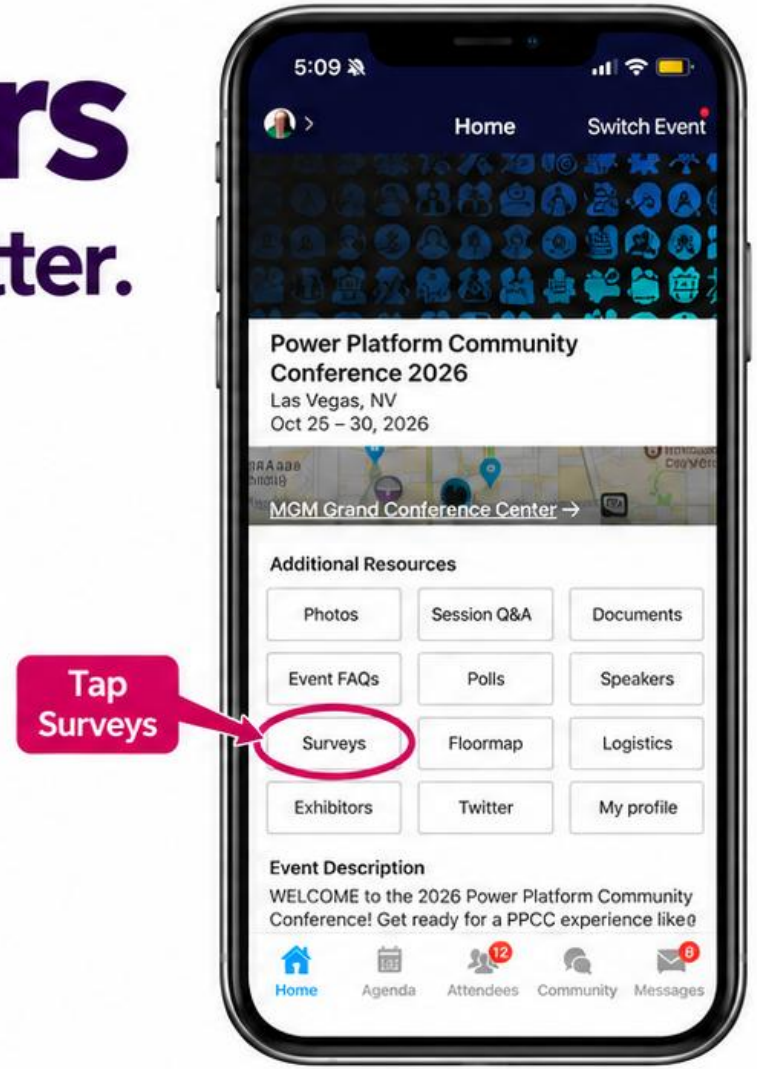
5thAnnual2026

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3. Select Session Feedback and find this session
4. Complete the survey and tap Submit

We'd love to hear what you think!

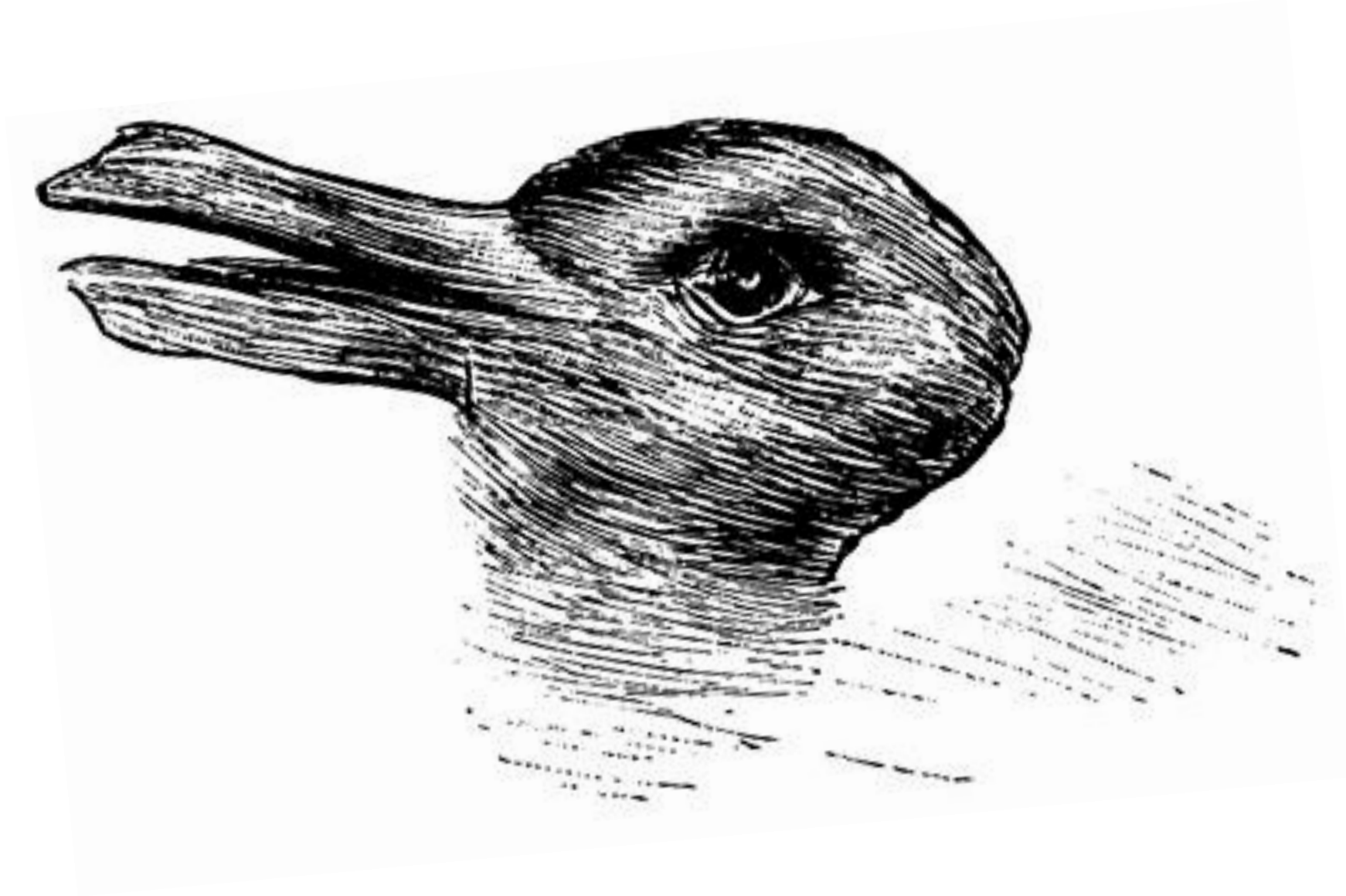


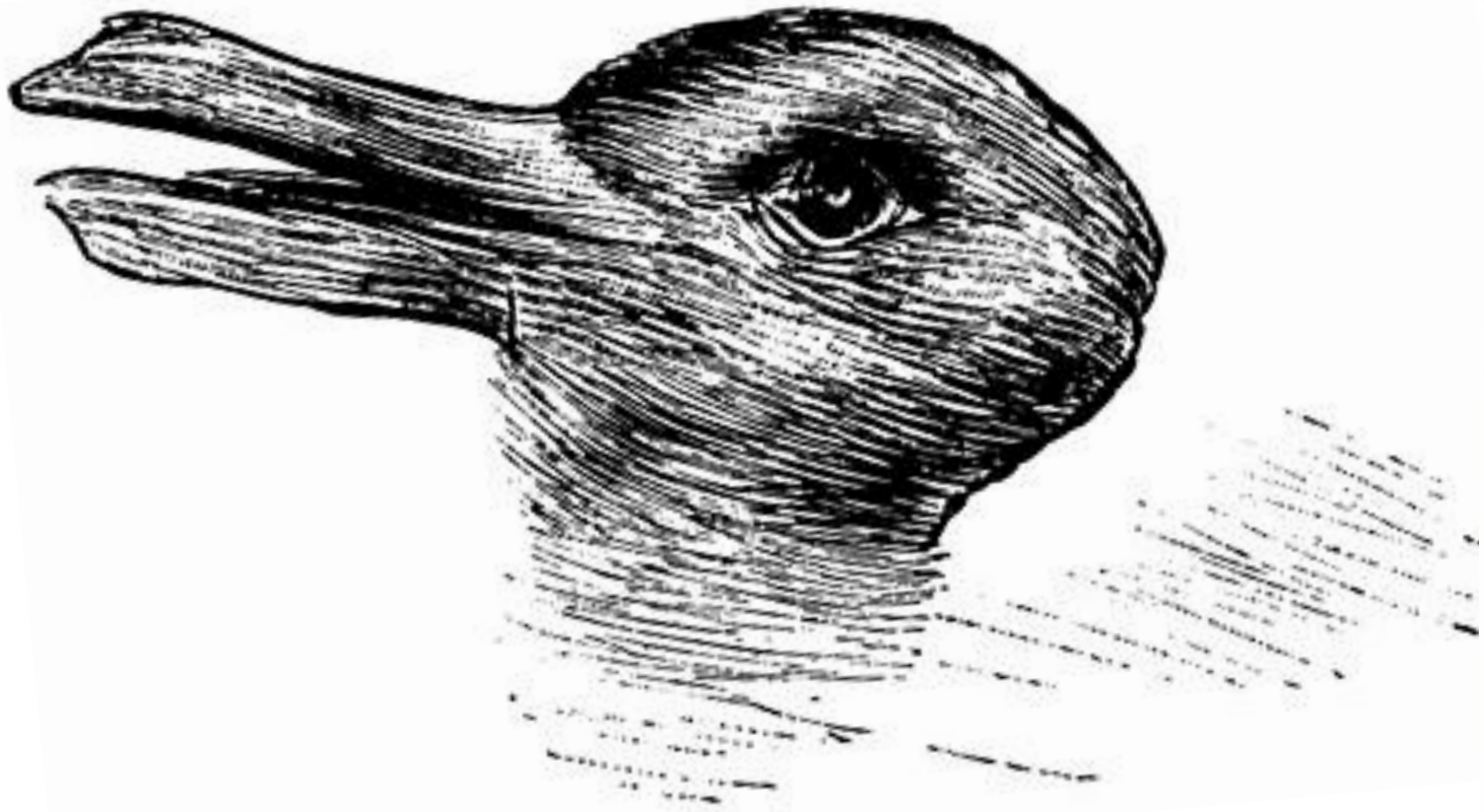
Activity Time

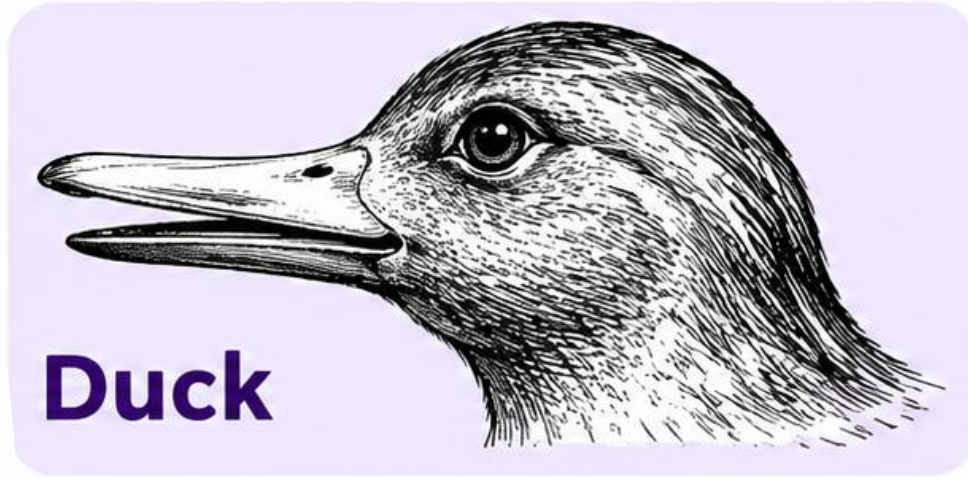


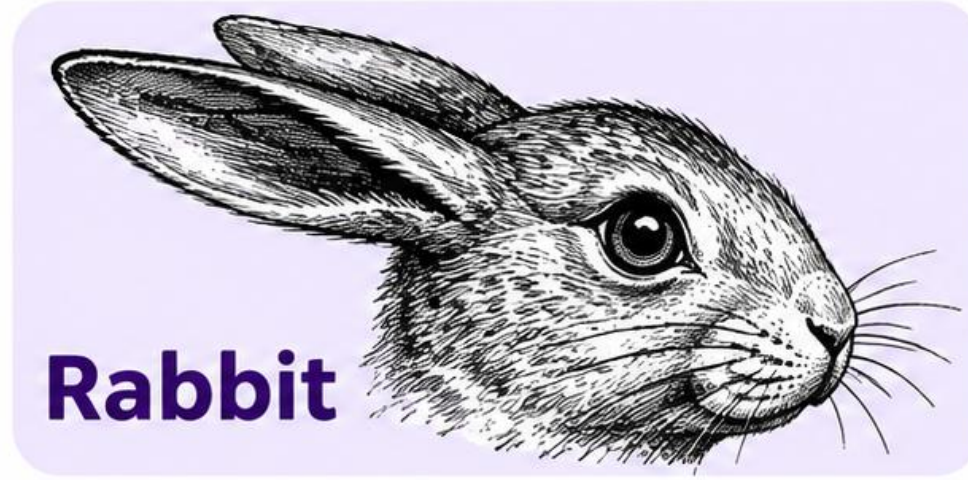
Can You Trust Your Eyes?



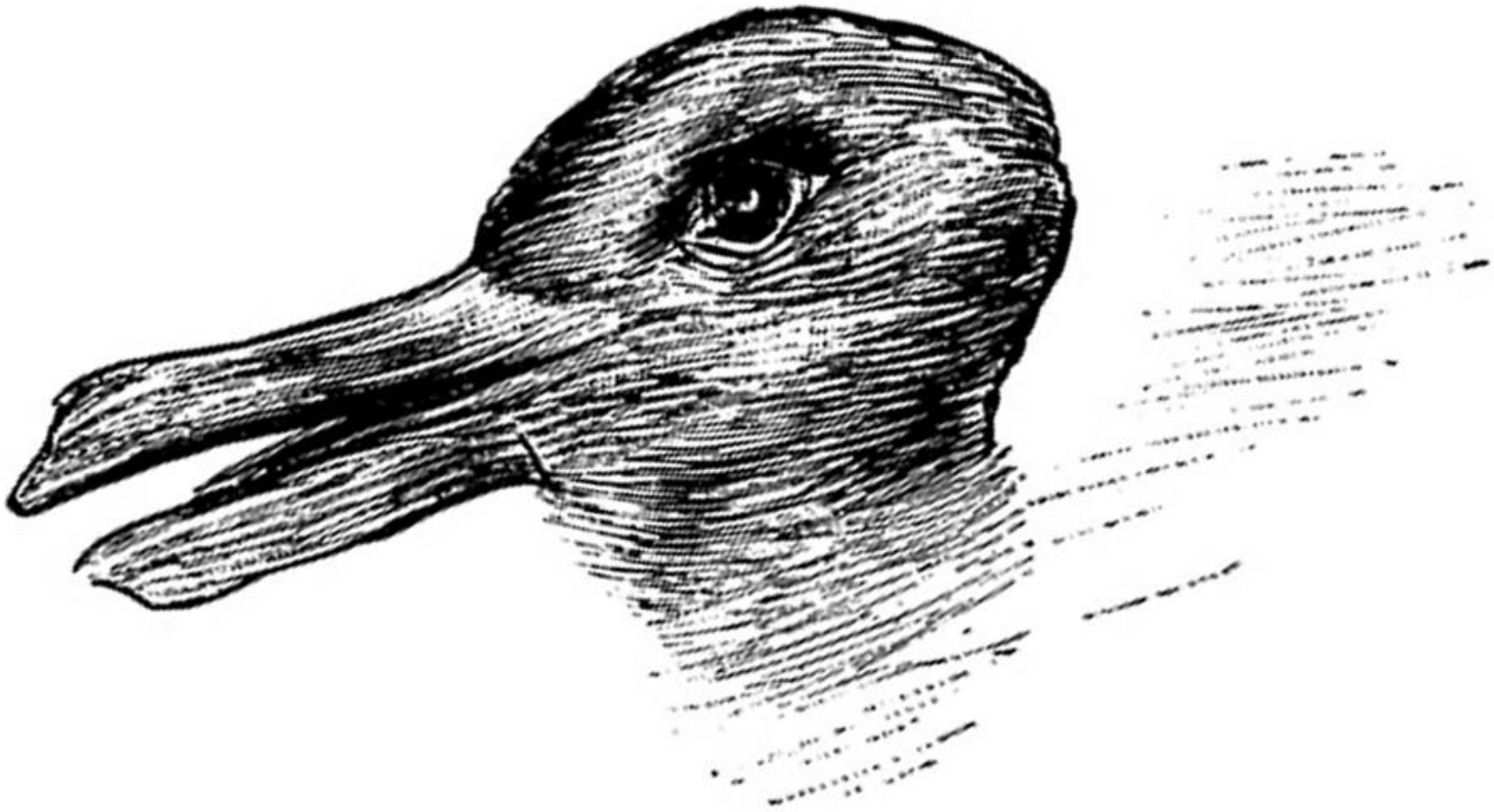


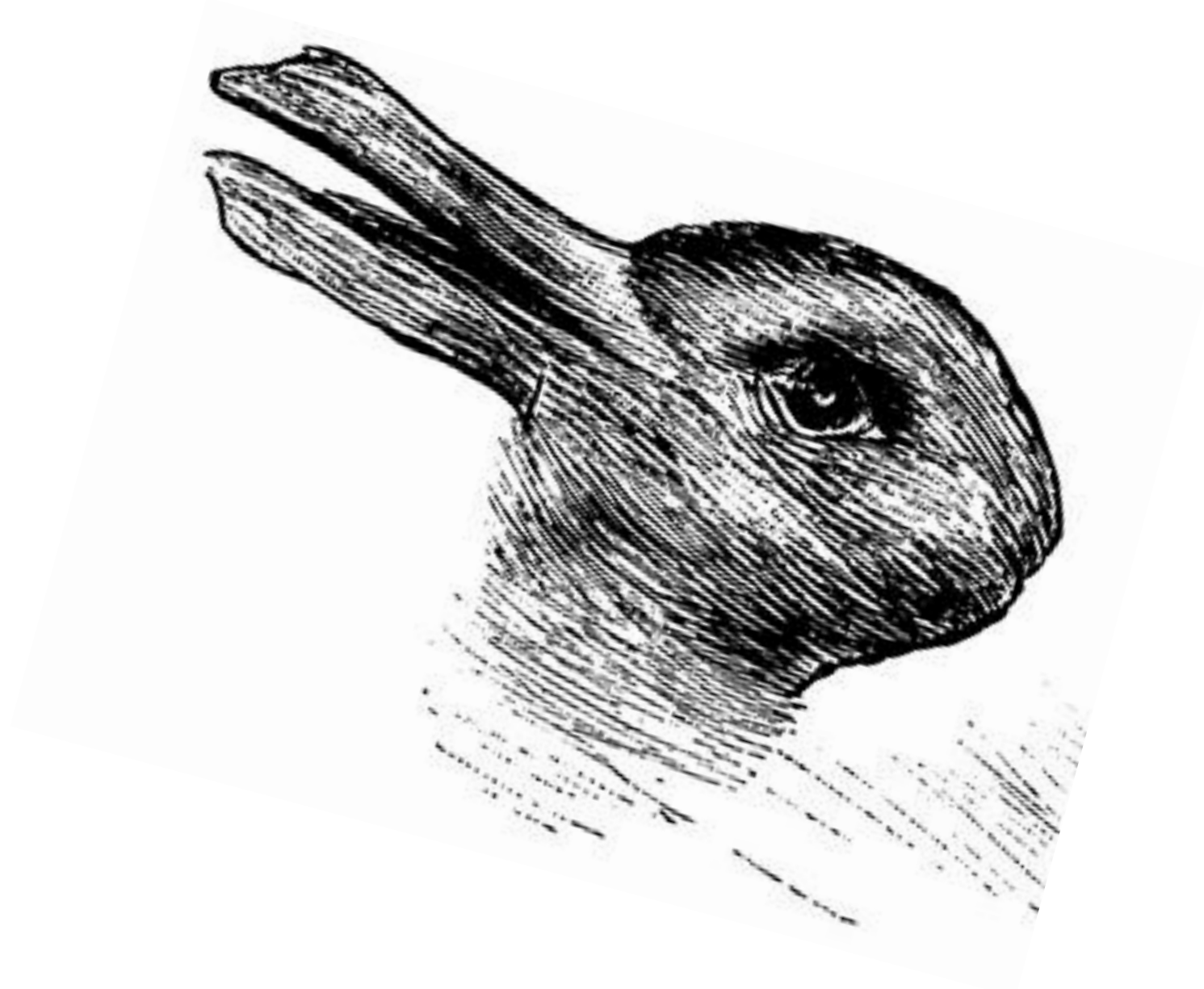


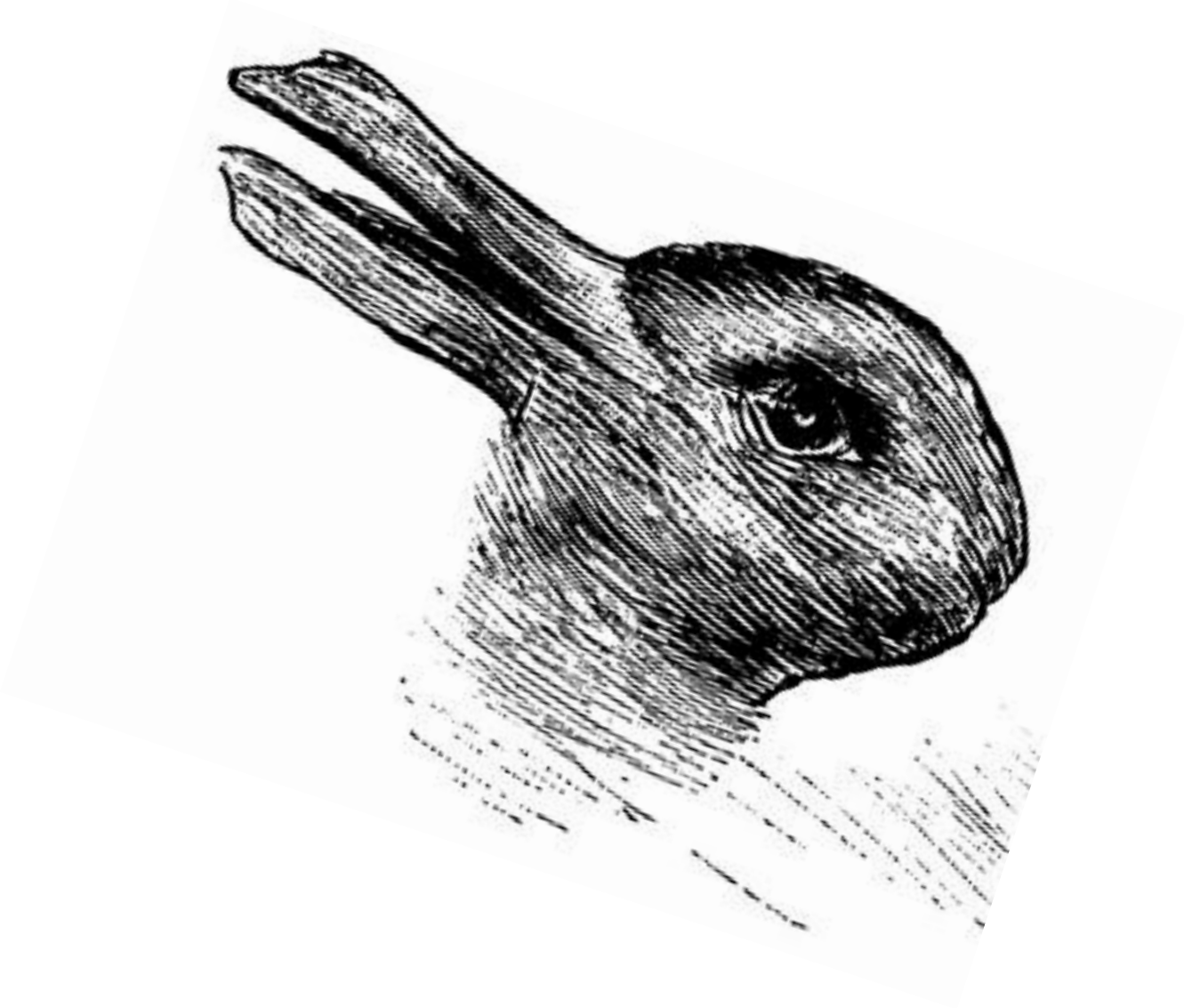

Duck

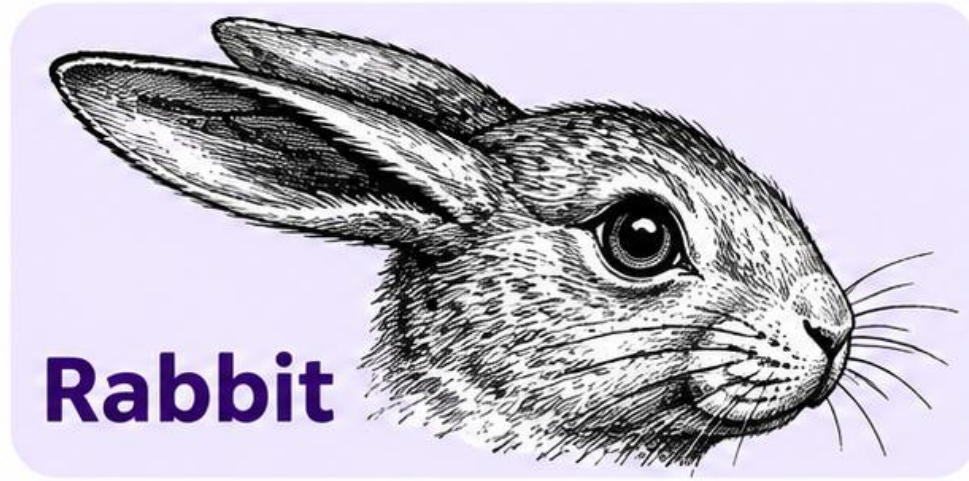

Rabbit

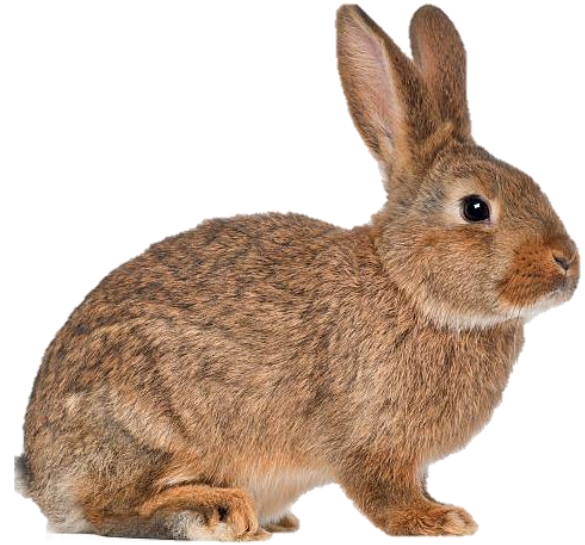
Let’s change the orientation

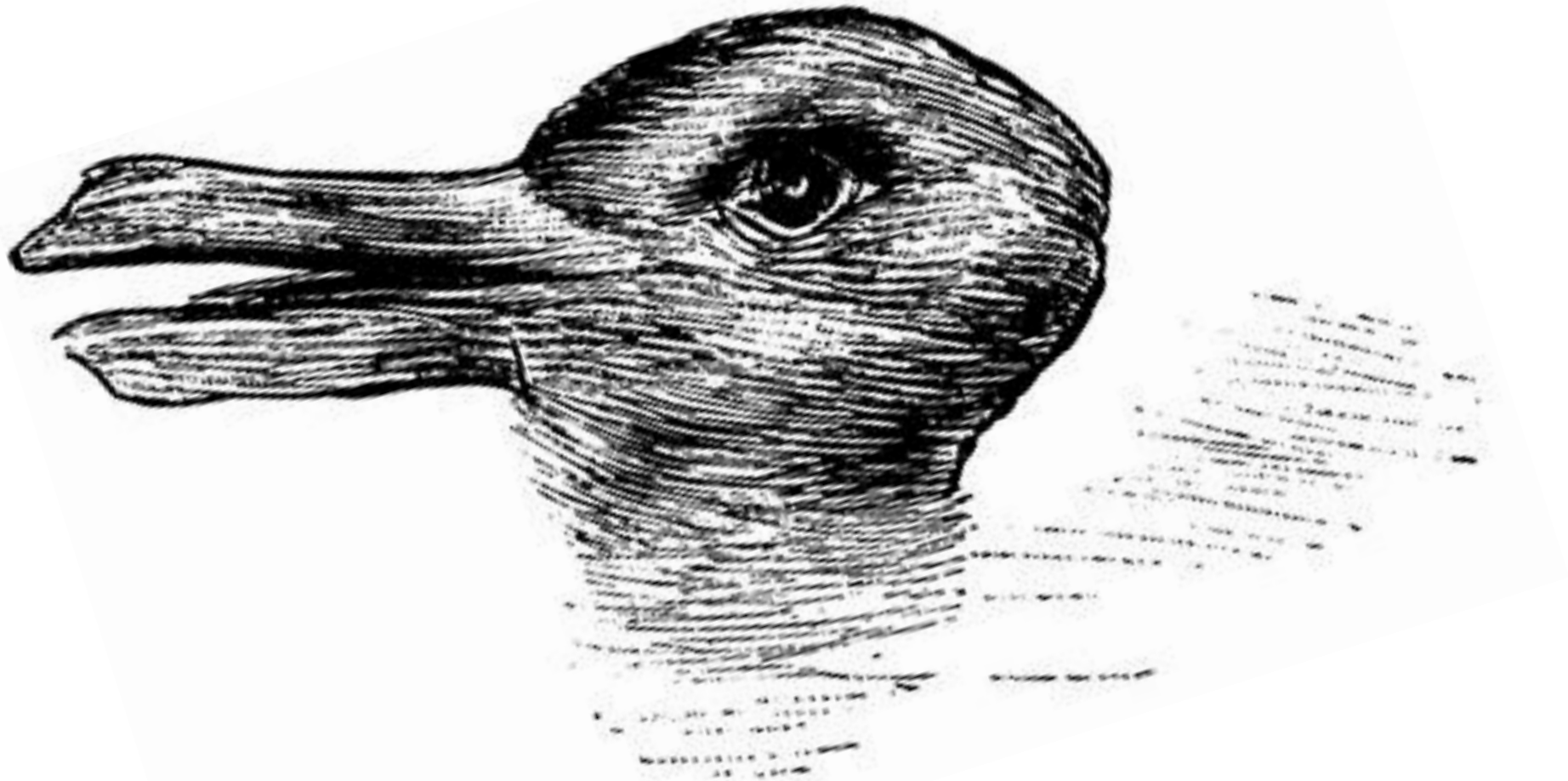


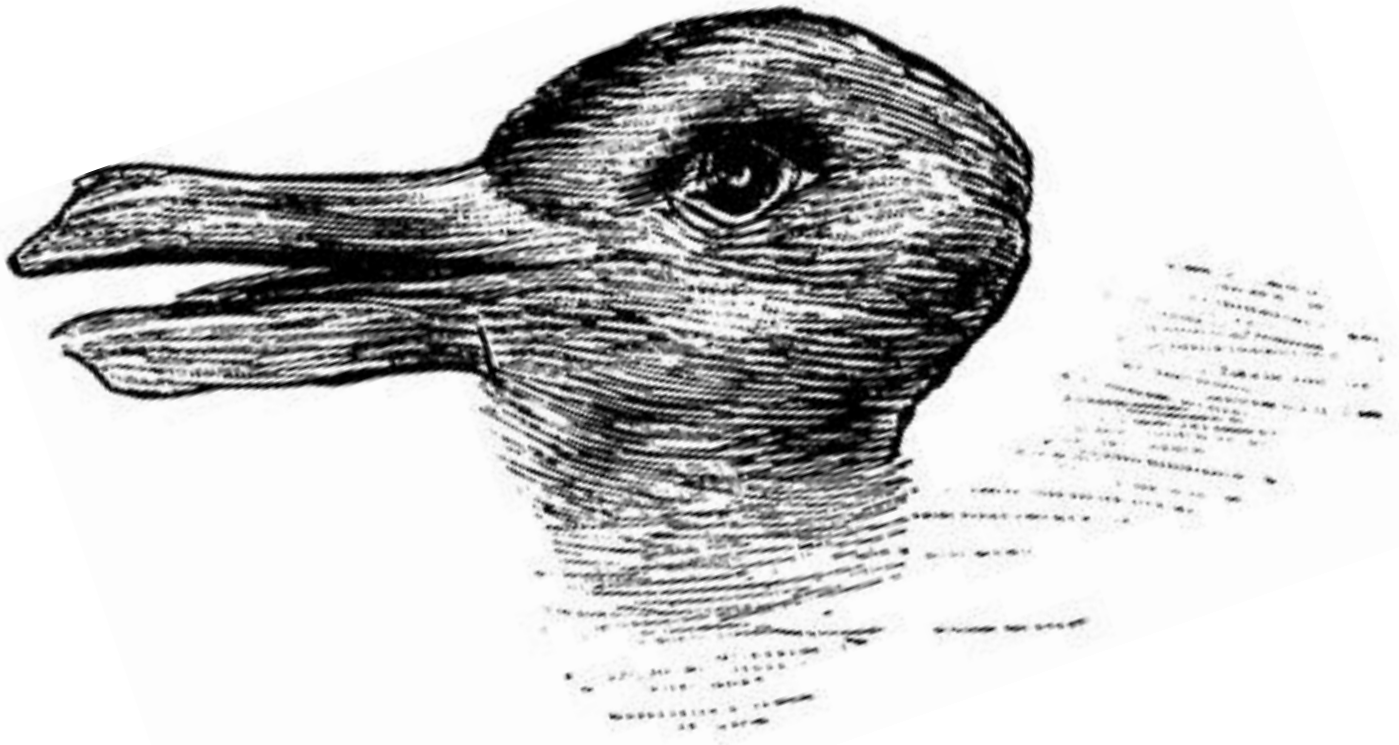


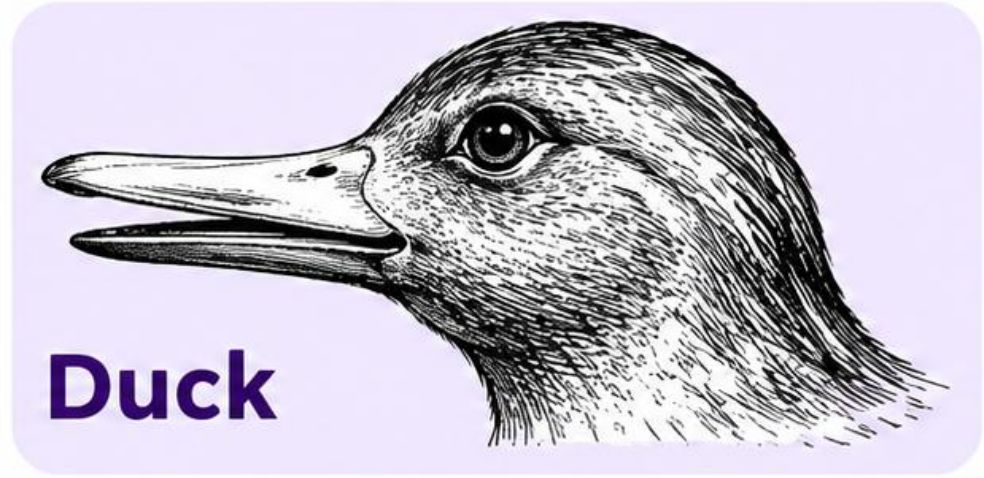


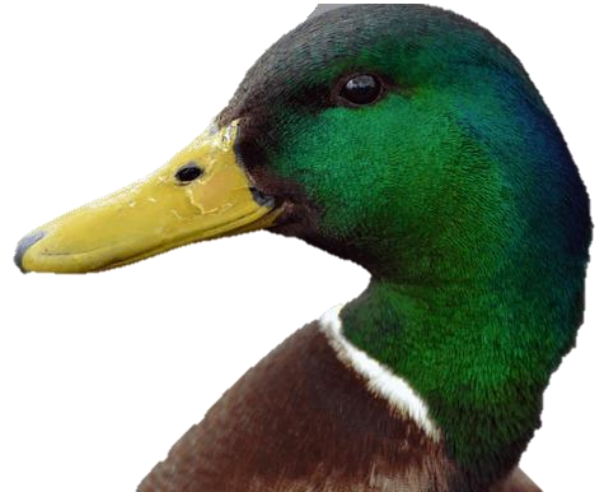

Rabbit



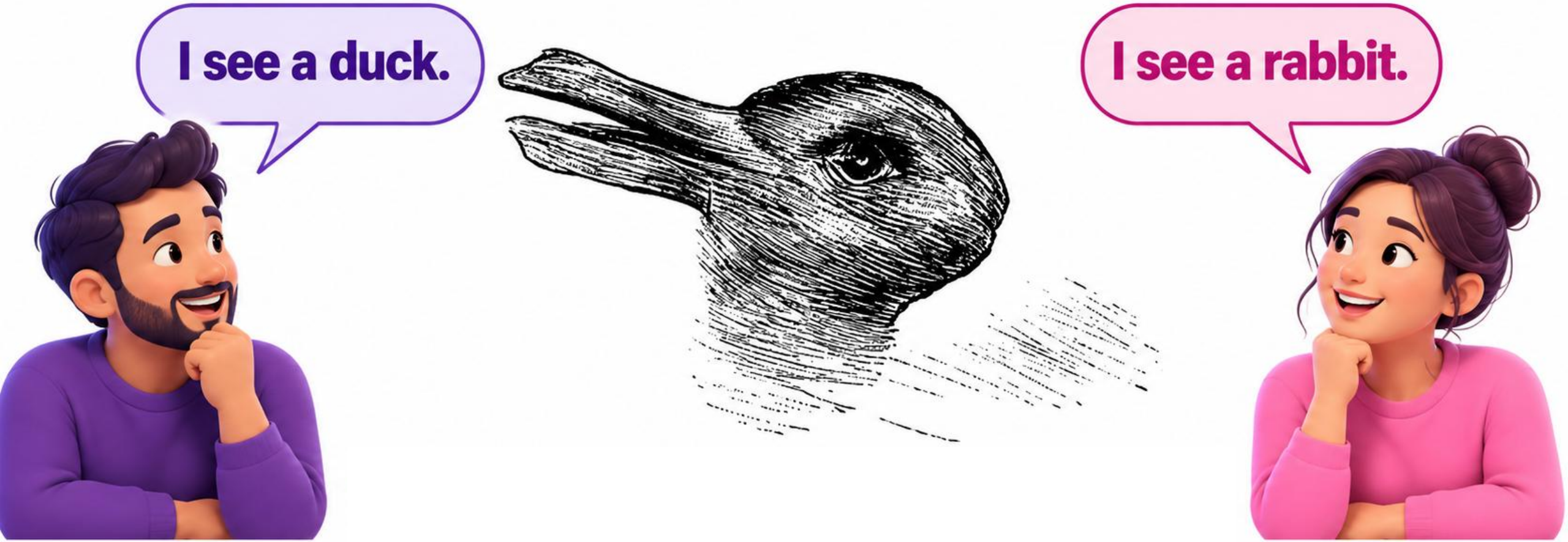


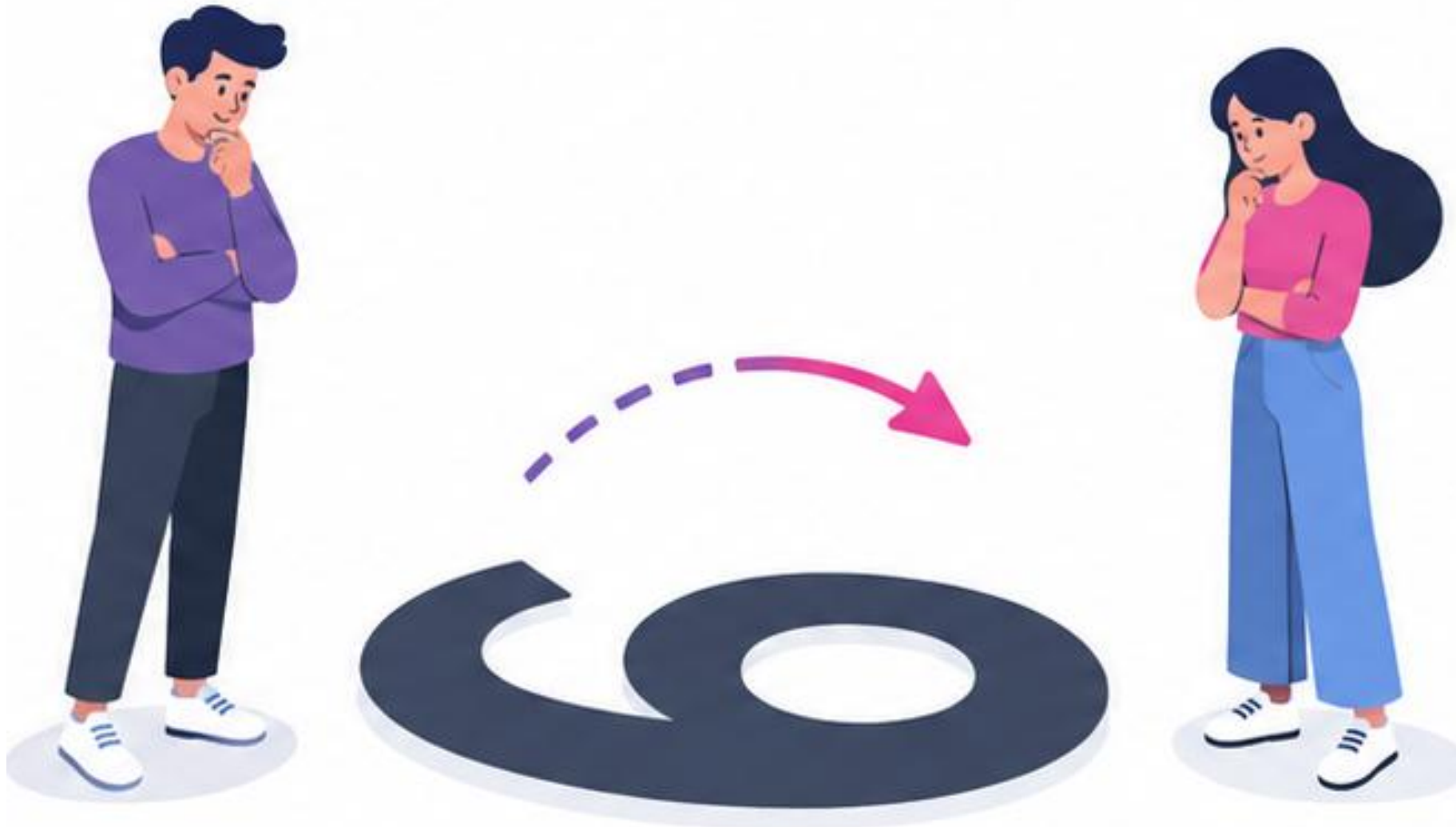



Duck



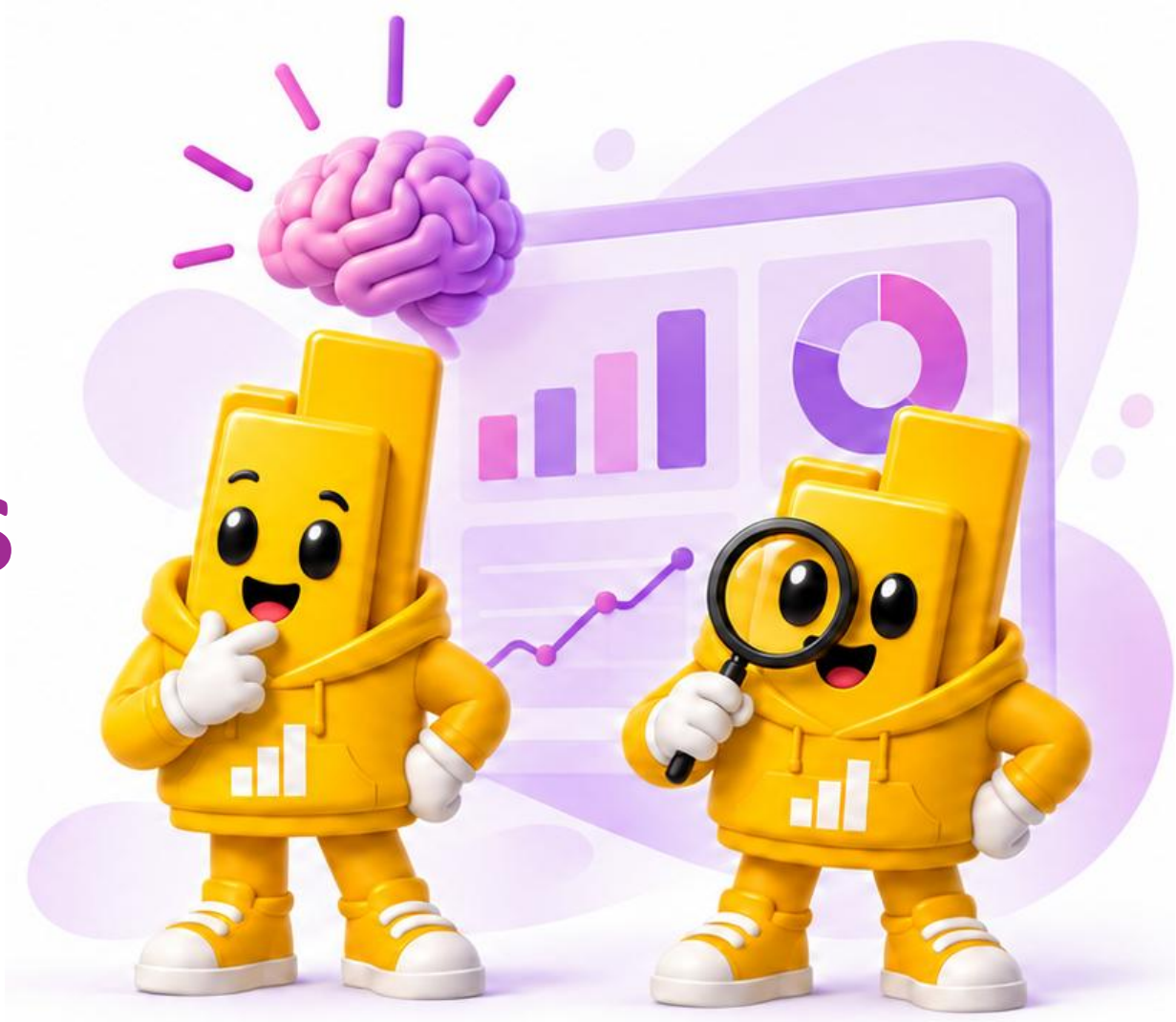

I ♥ DAD
What just happened?


I see a duck.
I see a rabbit.



Power Platform
COMMUNITY CONFERENCE

The Psychology Behind Powerful Power BI Reports



Hi, It's me!



Power BI DataViz 2025 & 2026

WORLD CHAMPIONSHIP FINALIST

Microsoft CERTIFIED POWER BI DATA ANALYST ASSOCIATE

MVP Microsoft® Most Valuable Professional

MISSOURI S&T

Data Analyst - Institutional Effectiveness







DIVERSITY & INCLUSION

Santhana Lakshmi Ponnurasan

Poll

What makes you want to keep using a Power BI report?



Poll created by speaker, Lakshmi Ponnurasan

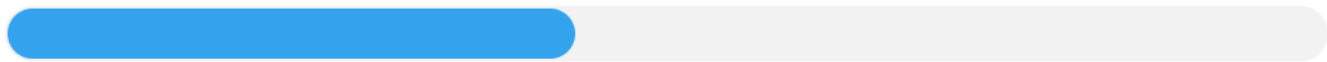
Poll Results **378 Answers**

It looks clean and visually appealing



245/378

I can easily find what I need



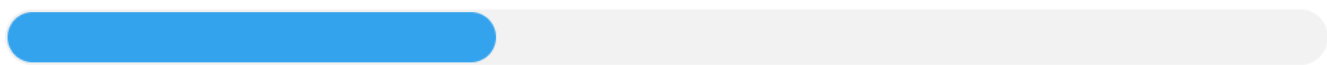
165/378

I quickly understand what the numbers mean



194/378

It helps me decide what to do next



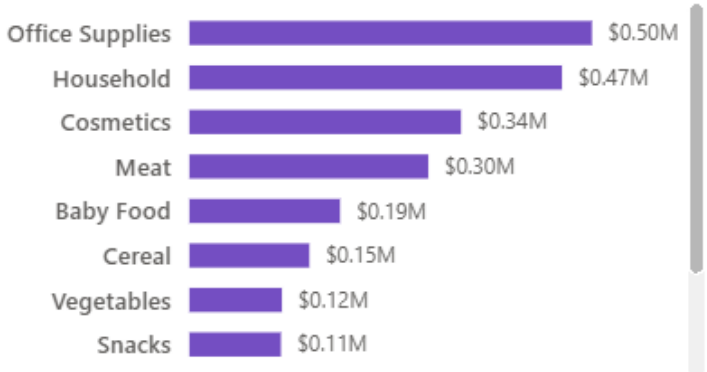
140/378


Why am I here?

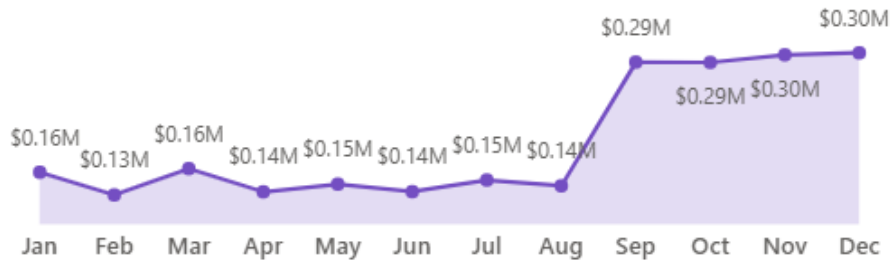
Year: 2020 | Quarter: All | Month: All | Order Priority: All | Sales Channel: All

Sales Trends

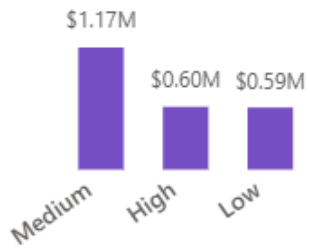
Total Sales
by Item Type



Total Sales
by Month



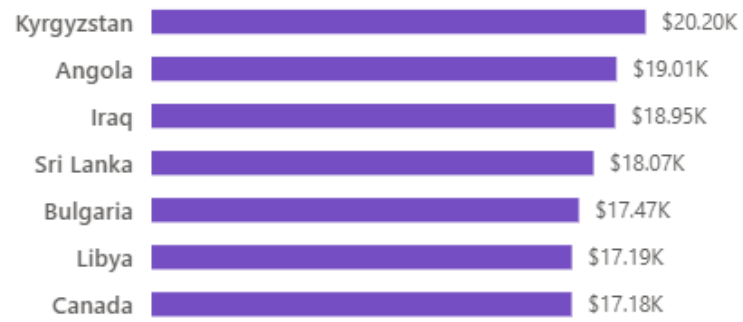
Total Sales
by Order Priority



Total Sales
by Sales Channel



Total Sales
by Country



Sales Summary

Item Type	Total Sales	Units Sold
Baby Food	$0.19M	3.6M
Beverages	$0.03M	3.5M
Cereal	$0.15M	3.7M
Clothes	$0.08M	3.7M
Cosmetics	$0.34M	3.9M
Fruits	$0.01M	3.6M
Household	$0.47M	3.4M
Meat	$0.30M	3.4M
Office Supplies	$0.50M	3.9M
Personal Care	$0.06M	3.6M
Snacks	$0.11M	3.7M
Vegetables	$0.12M	3.9M

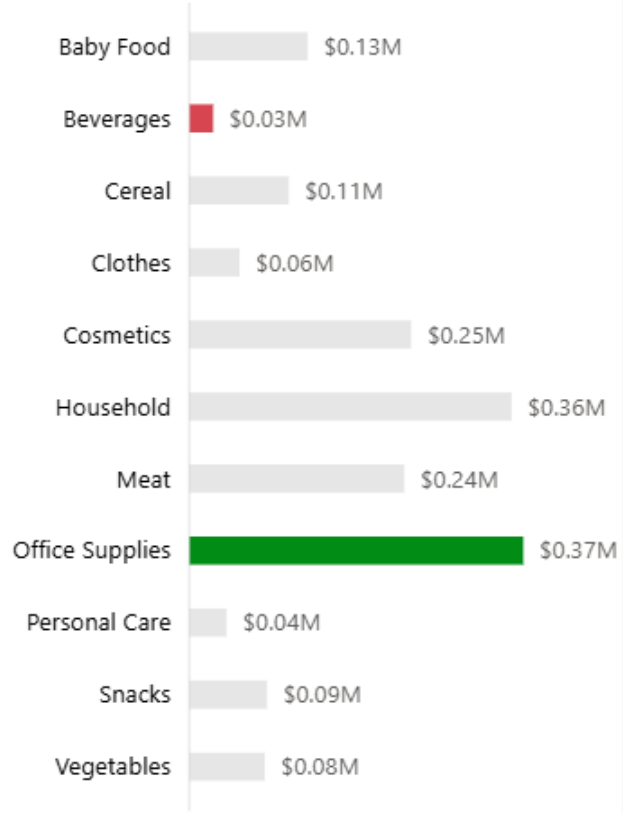
Total Sales	PY Sales	Total Units	PY Units	Total Cost	PY Cost
$2.36M	$1.76M	43.989M	33M	$1.66M	$1.24M

Sales Trends & Insights

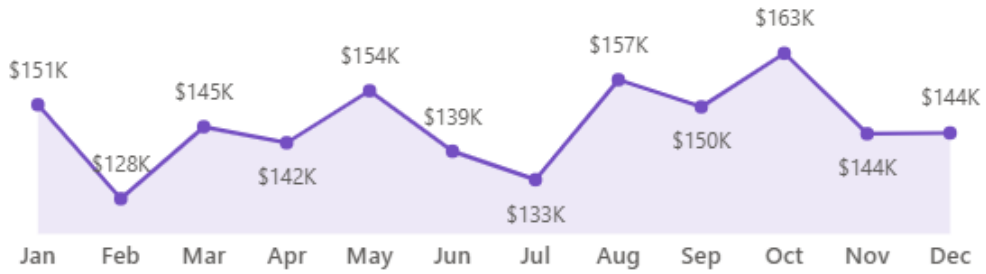
Year: 2014 | 2015 | 2016 | 2017 | **2018** | 2019 | 2020 | 2021 | 2022

Total Sales	Total Units	Total Cost	Total Orders
$1.75M	32.667M	$1.24M	6.508K
PY $1.74M ▲	PY 32.99M ▼	PY $1.22M ▼	PY 6.63K ▲

Total Sales
by Item Type

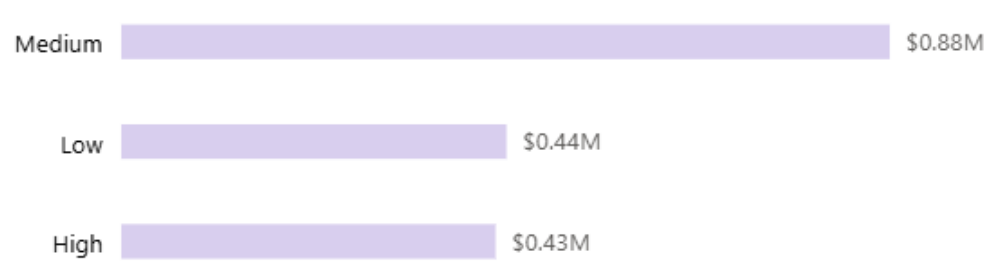


Total Sales
by Month



Total Sales
by Order Priority

Country | Order Priority | Sales Channel



Units Sold Summary

Item Type	Units Sold	Trend
Baby Food	2.6M	
Beverages	2.8M	
Cereal	2.8M	
Clothes	2.5M	
Cosmetics	2.7M	
Fruits	2.9M	
Household	2.7M	
Meat	2.8M	
Office Supplies	2.9M	
Personal Care	2.5M	
Snacks	2.8M	
Vegetables	2.7M	
Total	**32.7M**	


WOW, FINALLY!

Time to Pick



Time to Pick

Which interface would make it **easier** for you to choose a pricing plan?



1

$13* / mo

STARTER

Save $24 a year

CHOOSE STARTER

STARTER PLAN FEATURES

- ✓ 3 prototypes
- ✓ 3 boards
- — Team members not included
- — Advanced security not included
- — Permissions & workflows not included

$22* / mo

PROFESSIONAL

Save $36 a year

CHOOSE PRO

PROFESSIONAL PLAN FEATURES

- ✓ Unlimited prototypes
- ✓ Unlimited boards
- — Team members not included
- — Advanced security not included
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$89* / mo

TEAM

Save $120 a year

CHOOSE TEAM

TEAM PLAN FEATURES

- ✓ Unlimited prototypes
- ✓ Unlimited boards
- ✓ Up to 5 team members
- — Advanced security not included
- — Permissions & workflows not included

Let's talk

ENTERPRISE

For larger teams

SCHEDULE A DEMO

ENTERPRISE PLAN FEATURES

- ✓ Unlimited prototypes
- ✓ Unlimited boards
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- ✓ Advanced security
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2

STARTER

$13* / mo

Save $24 a year

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- — Not included
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CHOOSE STARTER

PROFESSIONAL

POPULAR

$22* / mo

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SCHEDULE A DEMO

* Plus applicable taxes

1

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2



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SCHEDULE A DEMO

* Plus applicable taxes

The Von Restroff Effect (Isolation Effect)



The Von Restroff Effect (Isolation Effect)

When multiple items are present, the item that **stands out** is more likely to be remembered.



The Von Restroff Effect (Isolation Effect)



We’re wired to notice **what’s different**- color, size, shape, or placement.

The Von Restroff Effect (Isolation Effect)

Why It Matters in Power BI?

Power BI dashboards are full of charts, numbers, and visuals.
Your job as a report designer is to **guide attention** intentionally.

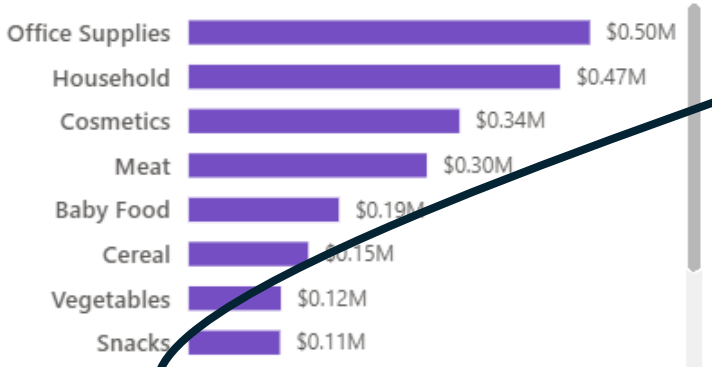
Highlight only what truly matters.

Year | Quarter | Month | Order Priority | Sales Channel

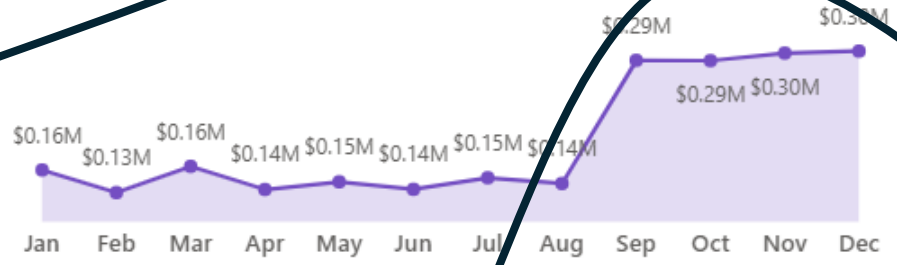
All | All | All | All

Sales Trends

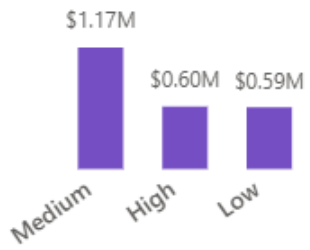
Total Sales
by Item Type



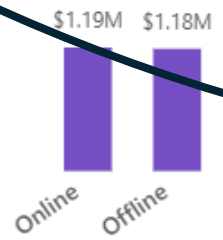
Total Sales
by Month



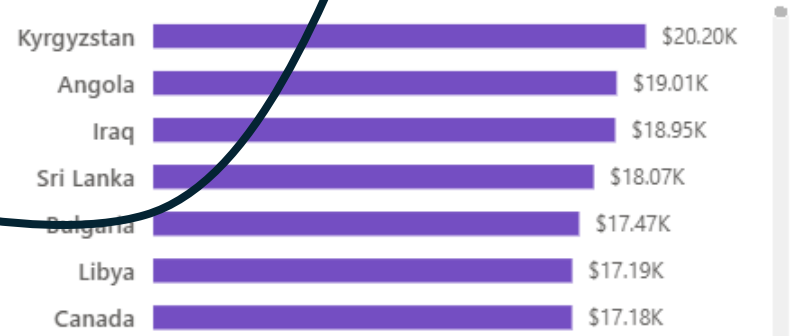
Total Sales
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Total Sales
by Sales Channel



Total Sales
by Country



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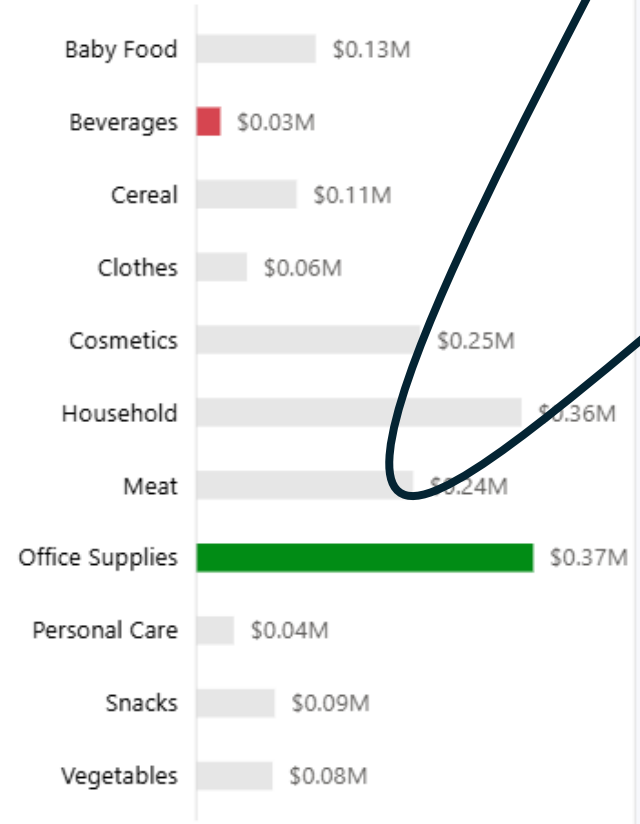
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Sales Trends & Insights

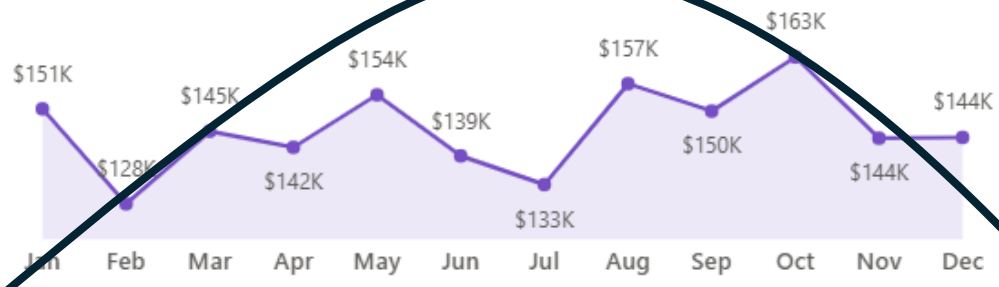
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Total Sales
by Item Type

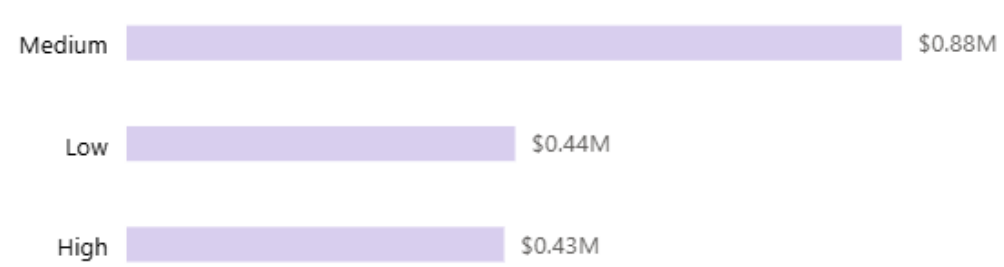


Total Sales
by Month



Total Sales
by Order Priority

Country | Order Priority | Sales Channel

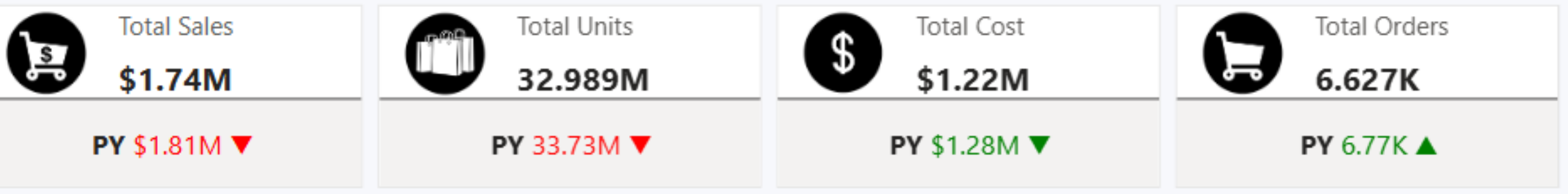


Units Sold Summary

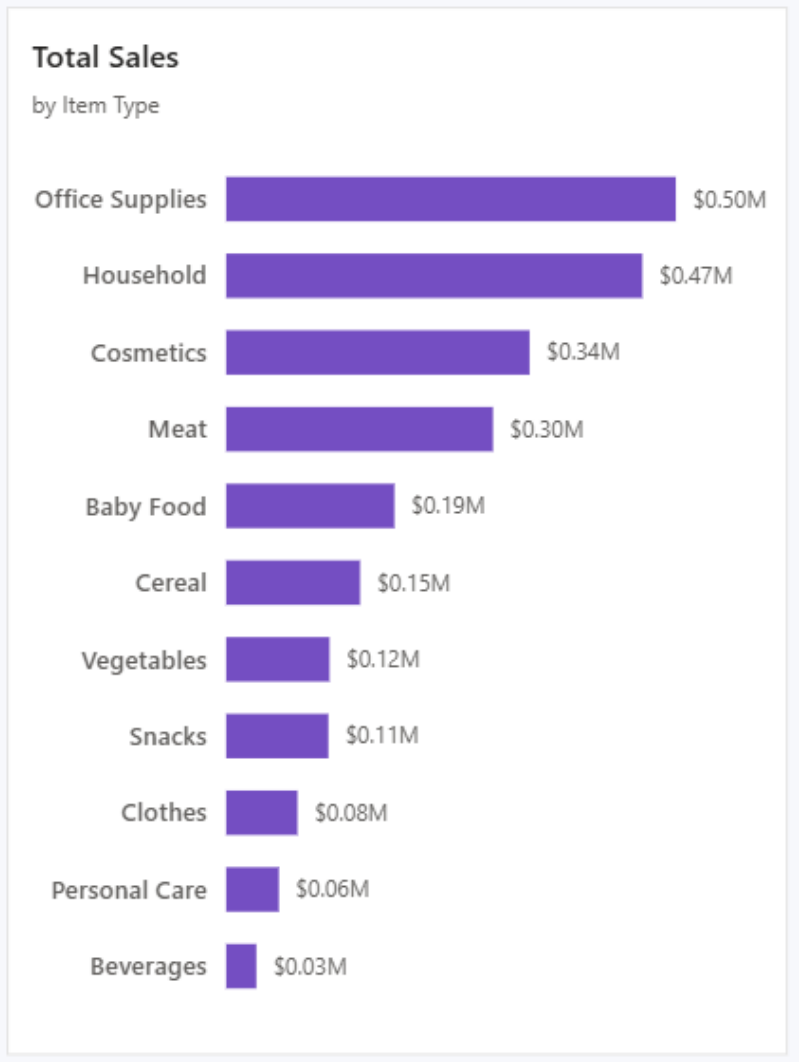
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Personal Care	2.5M	
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Vegetables	2.7M	
Total	**32.7M**	

The Von Restroff Effect (Isolation Effect)

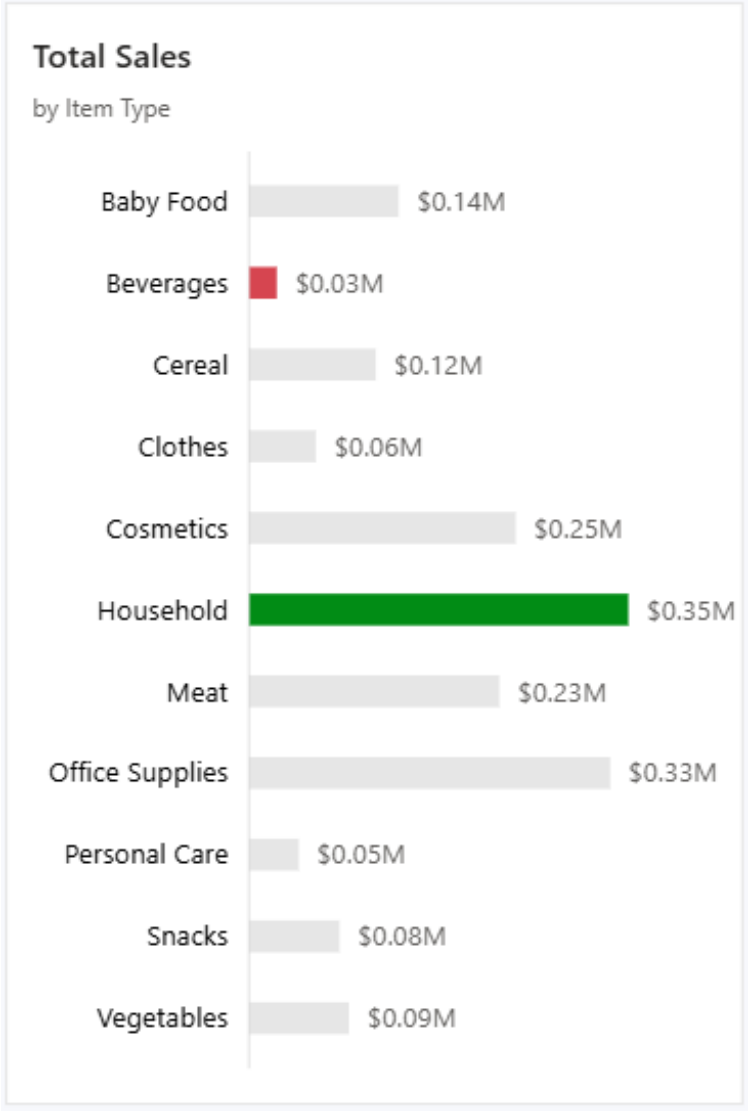
Total Sales	PY Sales	Total Units	PY Units	Total Cost	PY Cost
$1.74M	$1.81M	32.989M	34M	$1.22M	$1.28M



The Von Restroff Effect (Isolation Effect)



The Von Restroff Effect (Isolation Effect)



The Von Restroff Effect (Isolation Effect)

Techniques to Try

1. Highlight an exception or key insight.
2. Use text or symbols alongside color.
3. Use contrast through color, size, borders, or labels.

Time to Pick

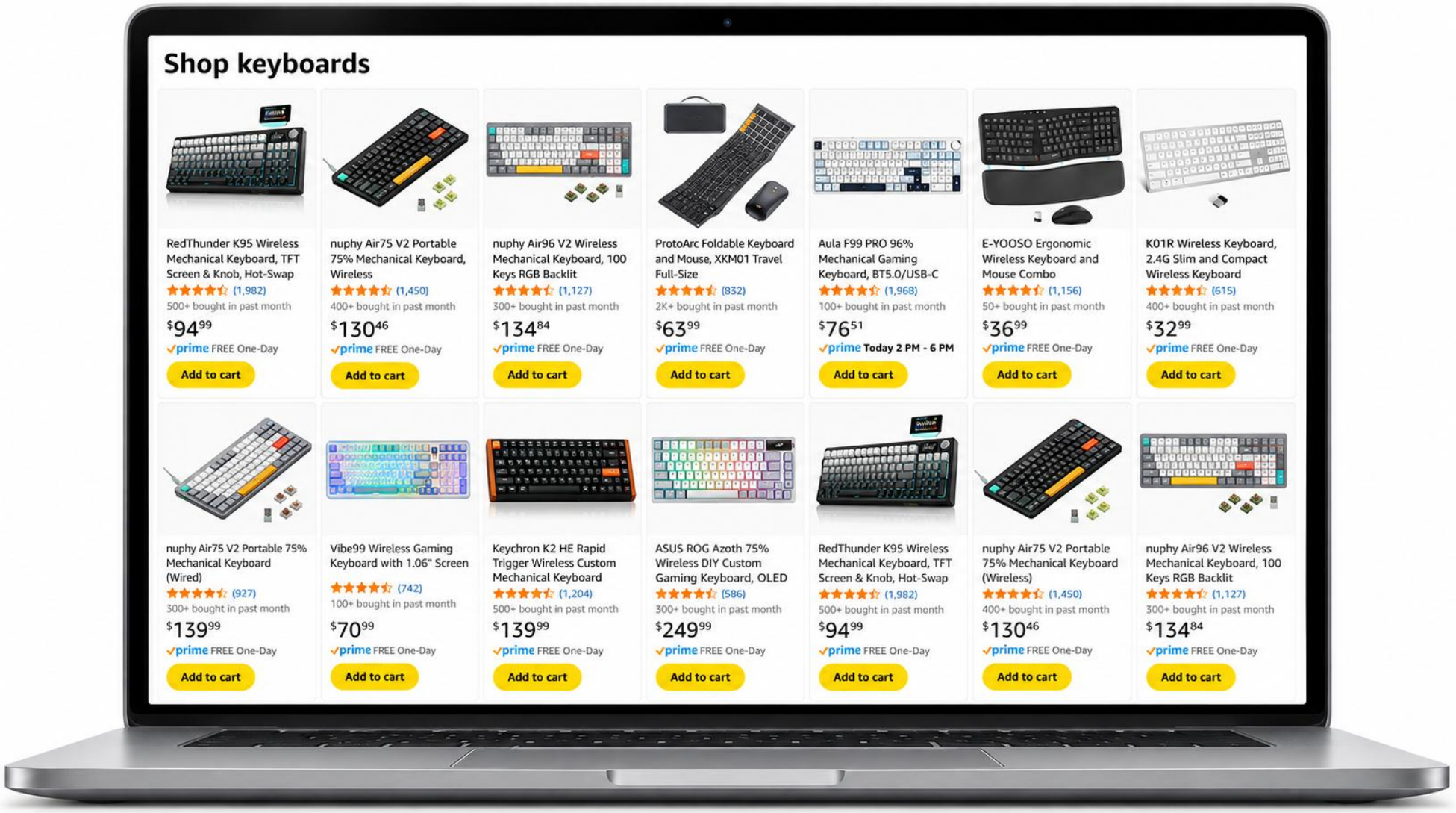


Time to Pick

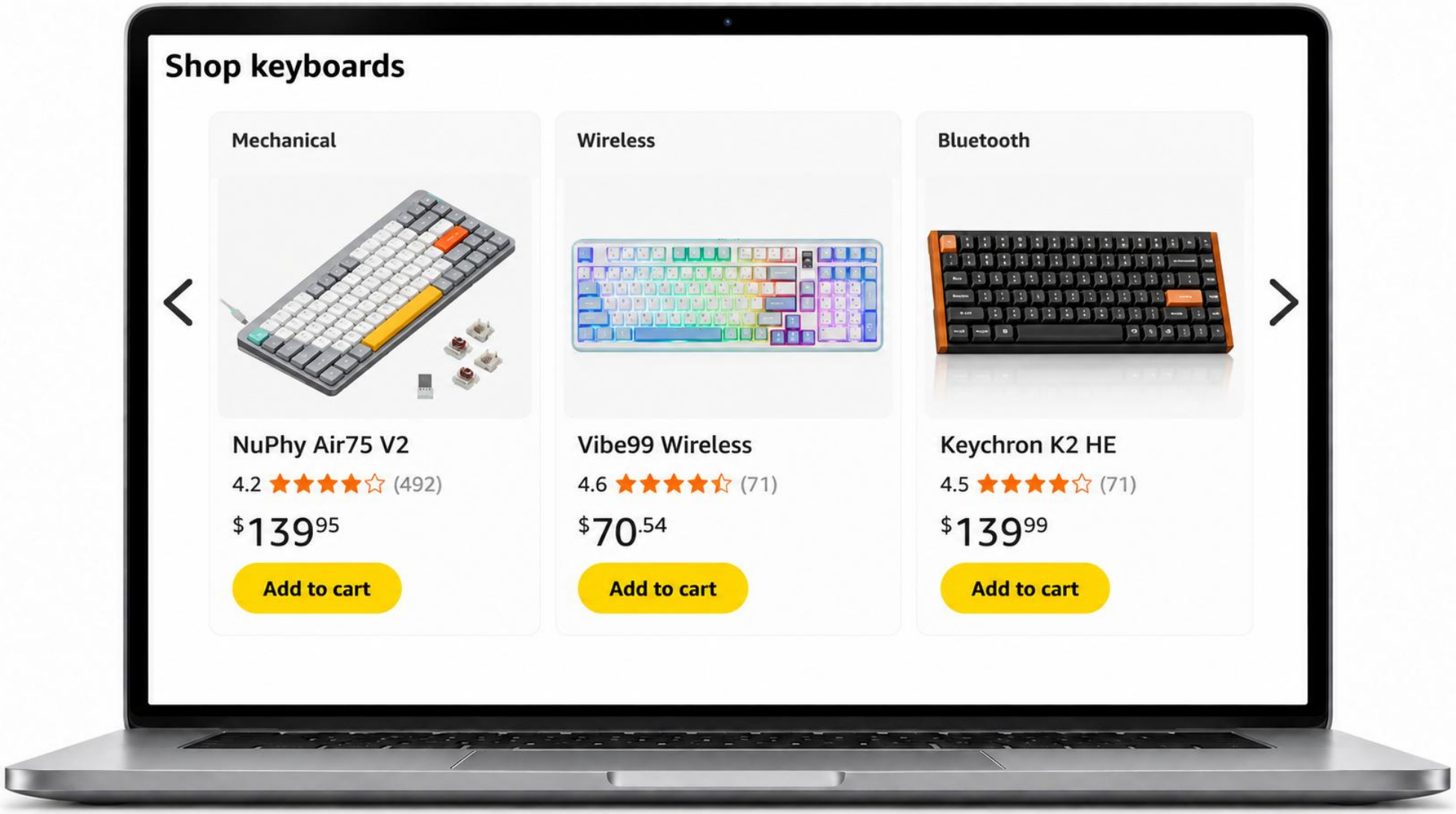
Which interface would make it **easier** for you to choose a keyboard?



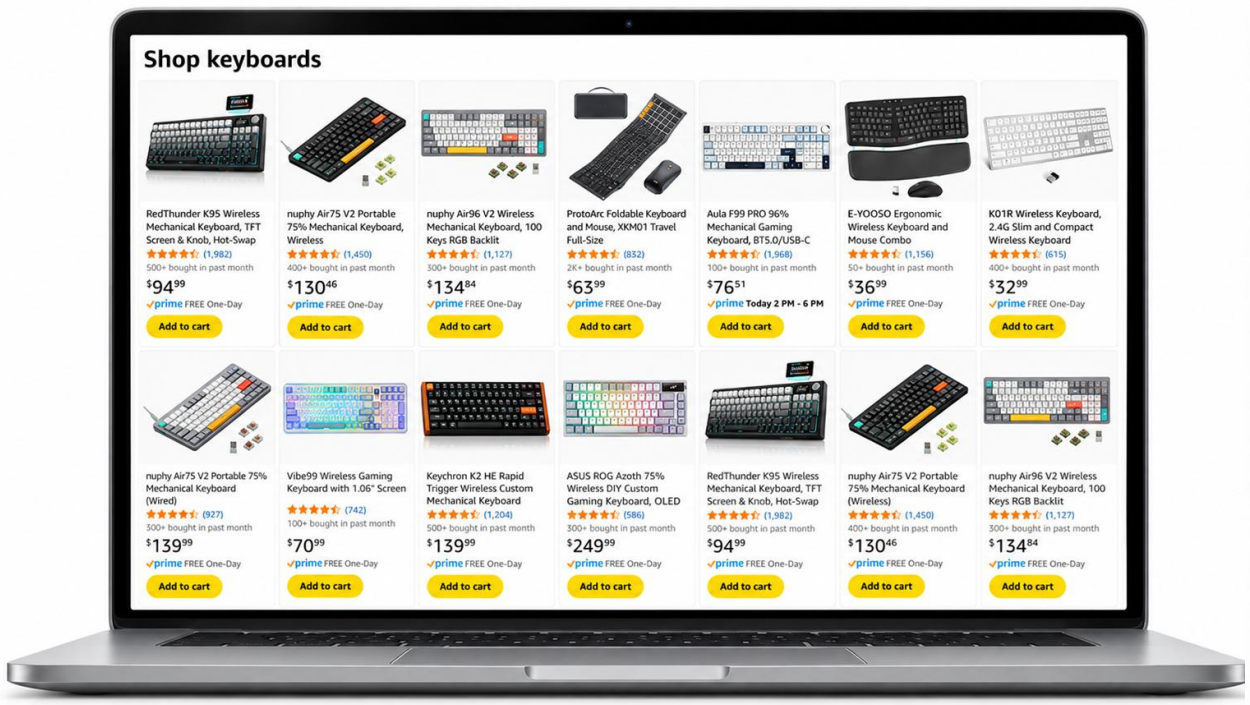
1


Shop keyboards
RedThunder K95 Wireless Mechanical Keyboard, TFT Screen & Knob, Hot-Swap
(1,982)
500+ bought in past month
$94.99
prime FREE One-Day
Add to cart
nuphy Air75 V2 Portable 75% Mechanical Keyboard, Wireless
(1,450)
400+ bought in past month
$130.46
prime FREE One-Day
Add to cart
nuphy Air96 V2 Wireless Mechanical Keyboard, 100 Keys RGB Backlit
(1,127)
300+ bought in past month
$134.84
prime FREE One-Day
Add to cart
ProtoArc Foldable Keyboard and Mouse, XKM01 Travel Full-Size
(832)
2K+ bought in past month
$63.99
prime FREE One-Day
Add to cart
Aula F99 PRO 96% Mechanical Gaming Keyboard, BT5.0/USB-C
(1,968)
100+ bought in past month
$76.51
prime Today 2 PM - 6 PM
Add to cart
E-YOOSO Ergonomic Wireless Keyboard and Mouse Combo
(1,156)
50+ bought in past month
$36.99
prime FREE One-Day
Add to cart
K01R Wireless Keyboard, 2.4G Slim and Compact Wireless Keyboard
(615)
400+ bought in past month
$32.99
prime FREE One-Day
Add to cart
nuphy Air75 V2 Portable 75% Mechanical Keyboard (Wired)
(927)
300+ bought in past month
$139.99
prime FREE One-Day
Add to cart
Vibe99 Wireless Gaming Keyboard with 1.06" Screen
(742)
100+ bought in past month
$70.99
prime FREE One-Day
Add to cart
Keychron K2 HE Rapid Trigger Wireless Custom Mechanical Keyboard
(1,204)
500+ bought in past month
$139.99
prime FREE One-Day
Add to cart
ASUS ROG Azoth 75% Wireless DIY Custom Gaming Keyboard, OLED
(586)
300+ bought in past month
$249.99
prime FREE One-Day
Add to cart
RedThunder K95 Wireless Mechanical Keyboard, TFT Screen & Knob, Hot-Swap
(1,982)
500+ bought in past month
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prime FREE One-Day
Add to cart
nuphy Air75 V2 Portable 75% Mechanical Keyboard (Wireless)
(1,450)
400+ bought in past month
$130.46
prime FREE One-Day
Add to cart
nuphy Air96 V2 Wireless Mechanical Keyboard, 100 Keys RGB Backlit
(1,127)
300+ bought in past month
$134.84
prime FREE One-Day
Add to cart

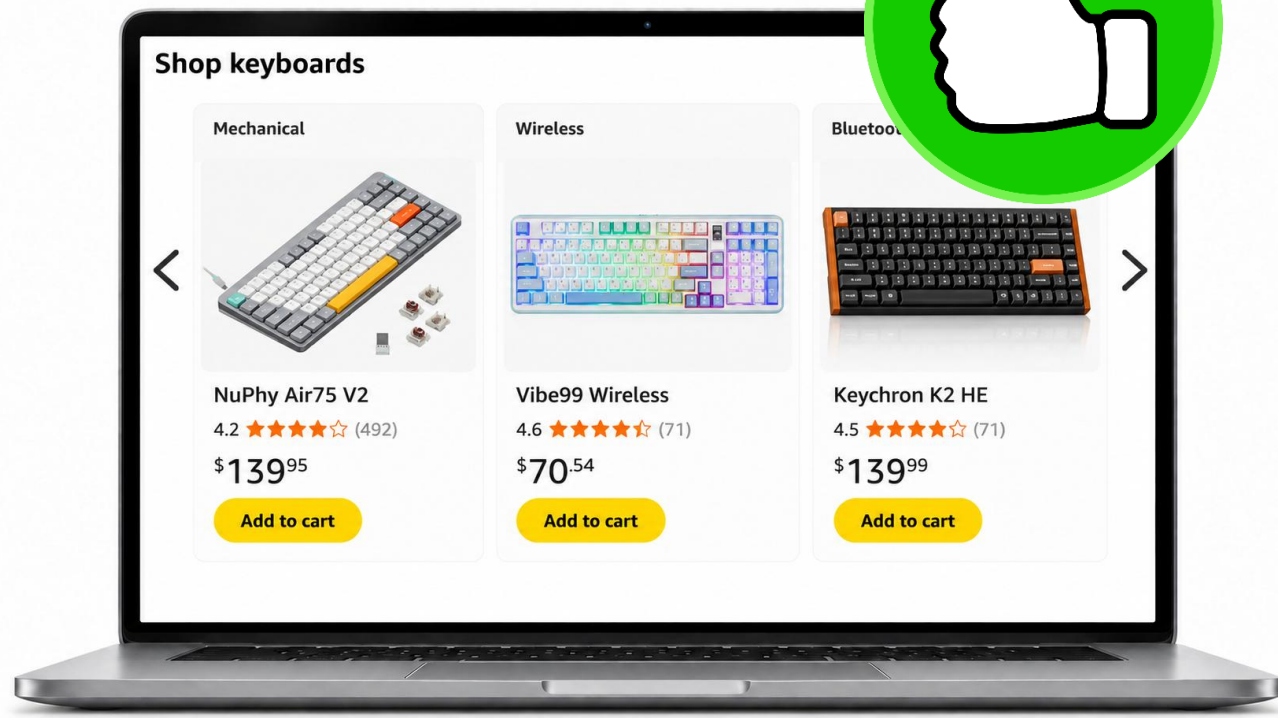
2


Shop keyboards
Mechanical
NuPhy Air75 V2
4.2 (492)
$139.95
Add to cart
Wireless
Vibe99 Wireless
4.6 (71)
$70.54
Add to cart
Bluetooth
Keychron K2 HE
4.5 (71)
$139.99
Add to cart

1


Shop keyboards
RedThunder K95 Wireless Mechanical Keyboard, TFT Screen & Knob, Hot-Swap
(1,982)
500+ bought in past month
$94.99
prime FREE One-Day
Add to cart
nuphy Air75 V2 Portable 75% Mechanical Keyboard, Wireless
(1,450)
400+ bought in past month
$130.46
prime FREE One-Day
Add to cart
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Add to cart
Wireless
Vibe99 Wireless
4.6 (71)
$70.54
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Keychron K2 HE
4.5 (71)
$139.99
Add to cart

Hick’s Law

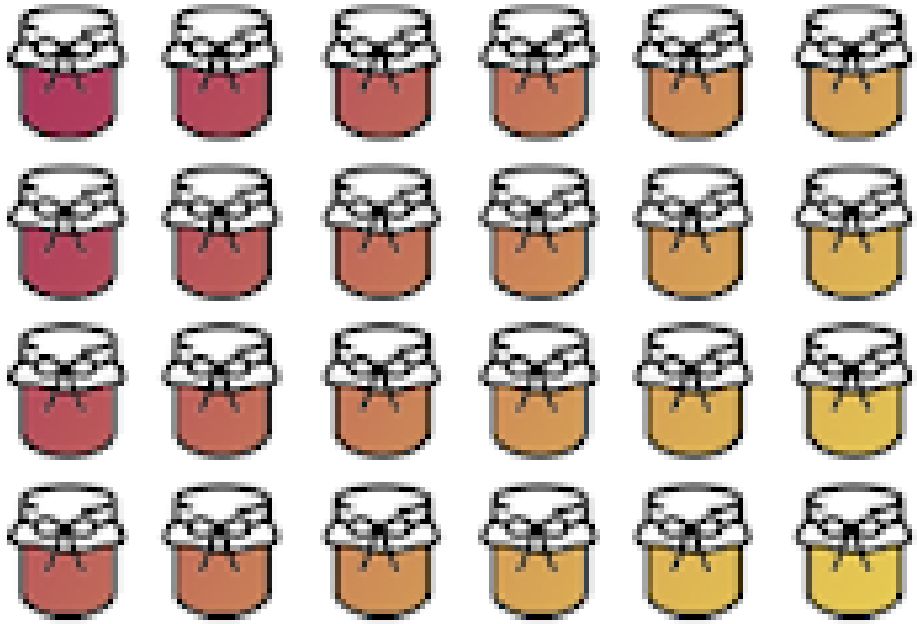


Hick’s Law

The more choices a user had, the harder and longer it takes to make a decision.



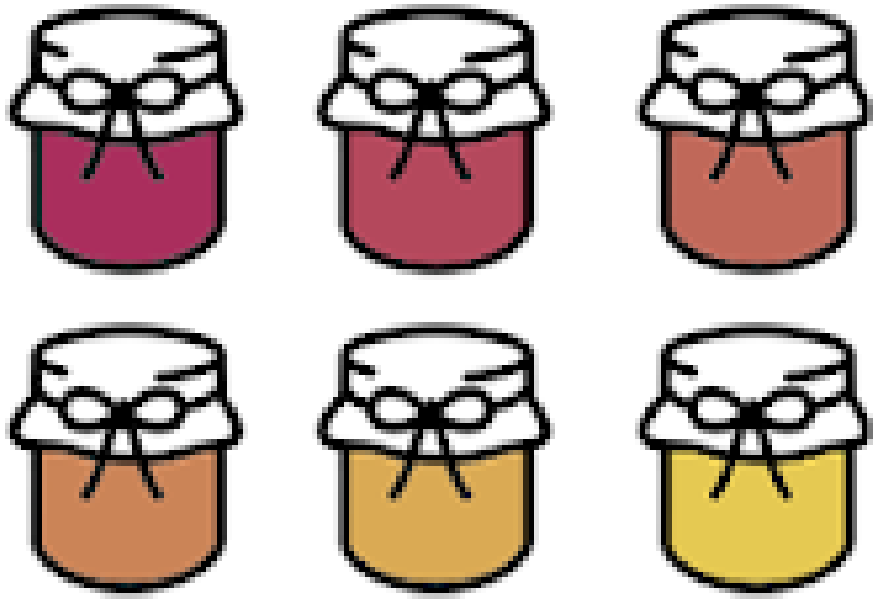
Hick's Law



24 choices of jam

attracted 60% of the shoppers

3% of shoppers bought jam

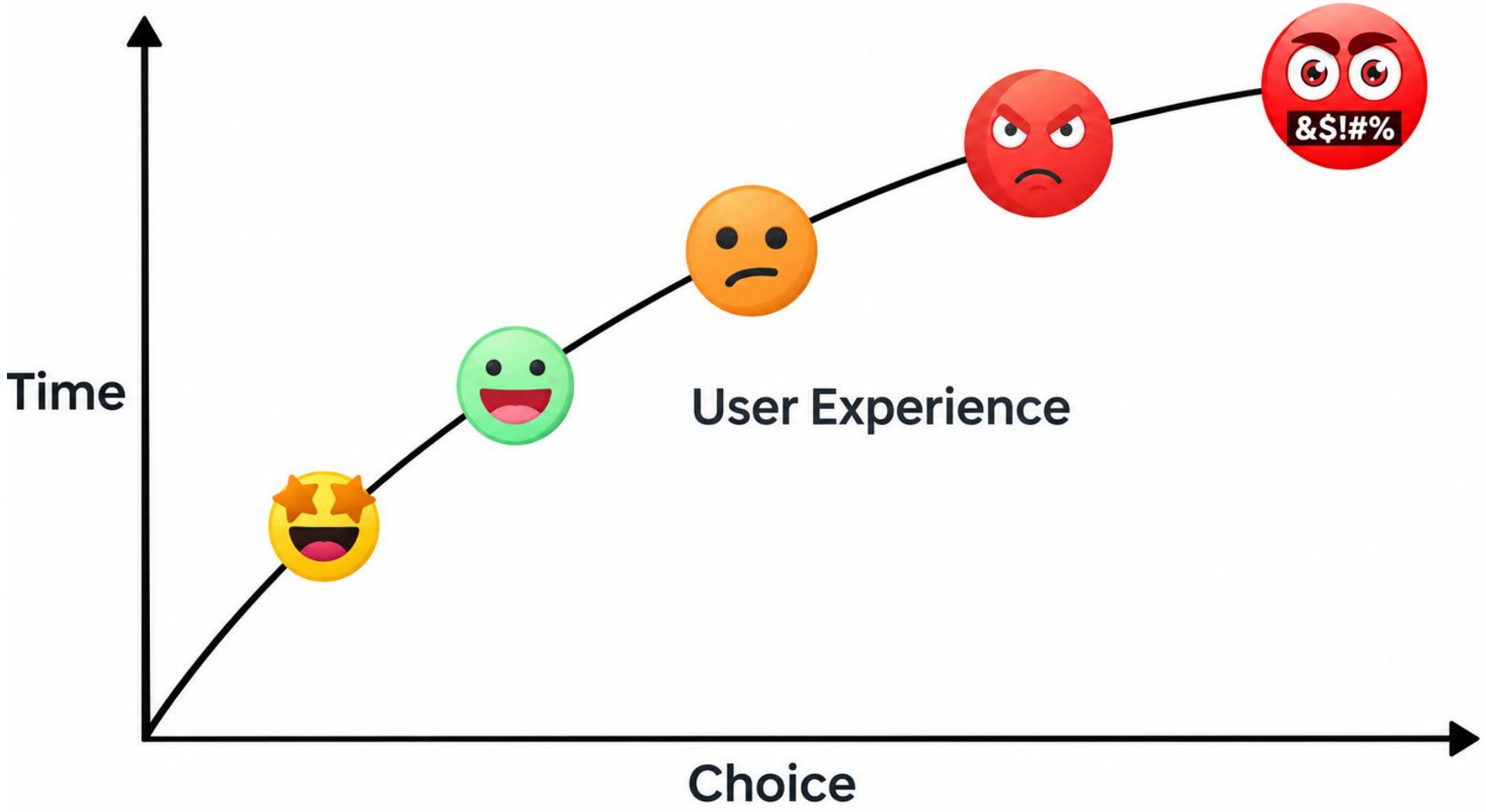


6 choices of jam

attracted 40% of the shoppers

30% of shoppers bought jam

Hick’s Law



Hick’s Law

Why It Matters in Power BI?

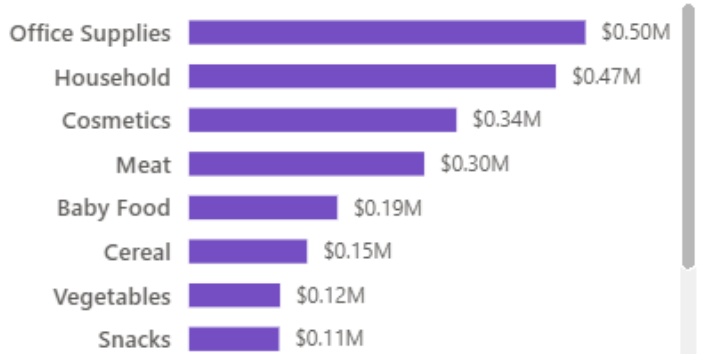
Power BI gives us endless freedom- slicers, filters, drilldowns, bookmarks. But **too many options** can paralyze your audience.

This leads to **Cognitive overload** → users freeze or leave.

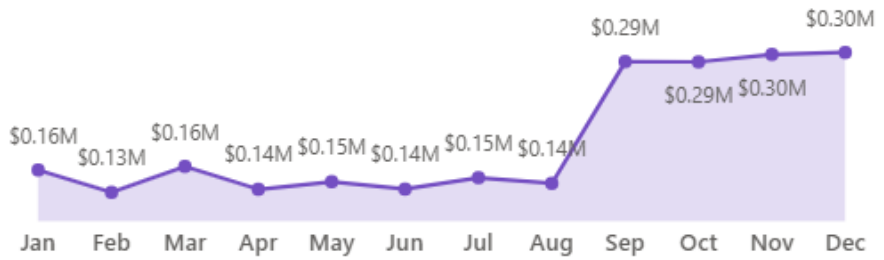
Year: 2020 | Quarter: All | Month: All | Order Priority: All | Sales Channel: All

Sales Trends

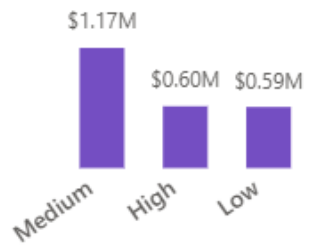
Total Sales
by Item Type



Total Sales
by Month



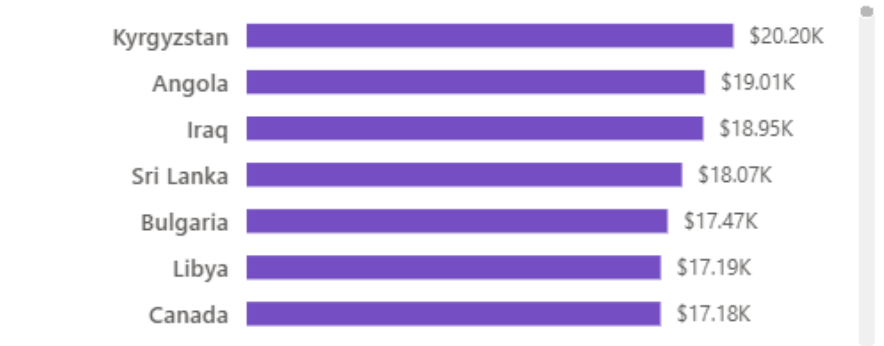
Total Sales
by Order Priority



Total Sales
by Sales Channel



Total Sales
by Country



Sales Summary

Item Type	Total Sales	Units Sold
Baby Food	$0.19M	3.6M
Beverages	$0.03M	3.5M
Cereal	$0.15M	3.7M
Clothes	$0.08M	3.7M
Cosmetics	$0.34M	3.9M
Fruits	$0.01M	3.6M
Household	$0.47M	3.4M
Meat	$0.30M	3.4M
Office Supplies	$0.50M	3.9M
Personal Care	$0.06M	3.6M
Snacks	$0.11M	3.7M
Vegetables	$0.12M	3.9M

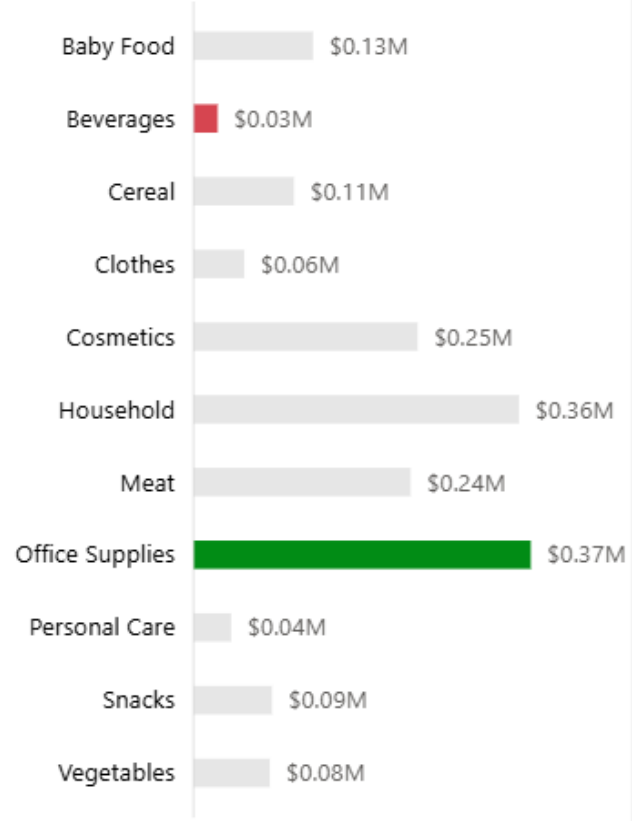
Total Sales	PY Sales	Total Units	PY Units	Total Cost	PY Cost
$2.36M	$1.76M	43.989M	33M	$1.66M	$1.24M

Sales Trends & Insights

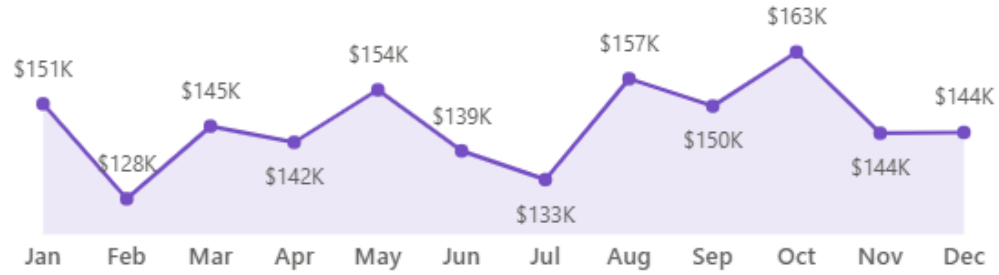
Year: 2014 | 2015 | 2016 | 2017 | **2018** | 2019 | 2020 | 2021 | 2022

Total Sales	Total Units	Total Cost	Total Orders
$1.75M	32.667M	$1.24M	6.508K
PY $1.74M ▲	PY 32.99M ▼	PY $1.22M ▼	PY 6.63K ▲

Total Sales
by Item Type

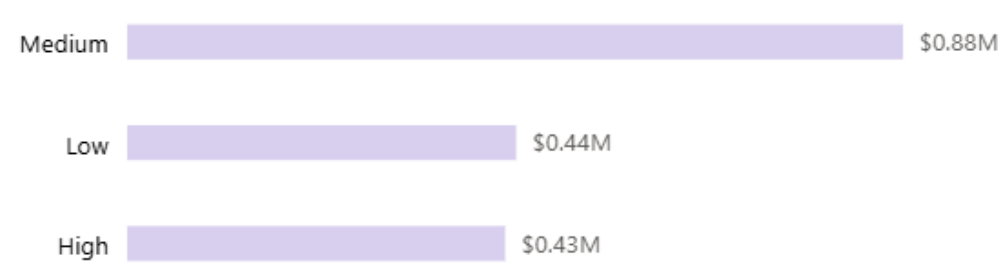


Total Sales
by Month



Total Sales
by Order Priority

Country | Order Priority | Sales Channel



Units Sold Summary

Item Type	Units Sold	Trend
Baby Food	2.6M	
Beverages	2.8M	
Cereal	2.8M	
Clothes	2.5M	
Cosmetics	2.7M	
Fruits	2.9M	
Household	2.7M	
Meat	2.8M	
Office Supplies	2.9M	
Personal Care	2.5M	
Snacks	2.8M	
Vegetables	2.7M	
Total	**32.7M**	

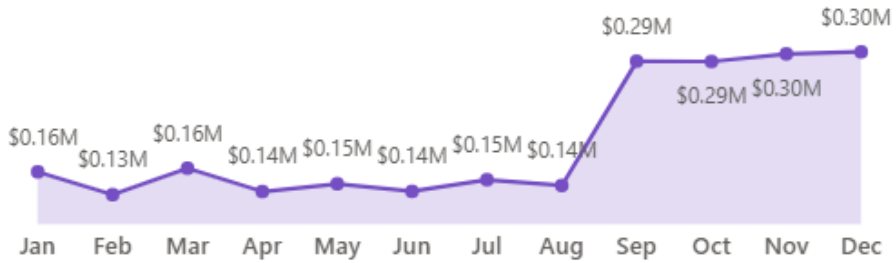
Year: 2020 | Quarter: All | Month: All | Order Priority: All | Sales Channel: All

Sales Trends

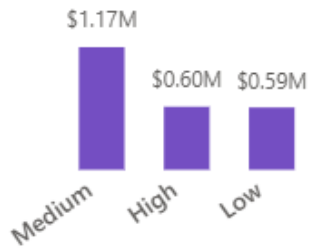
Total Sales
by Item Type



Total Sales
by Month



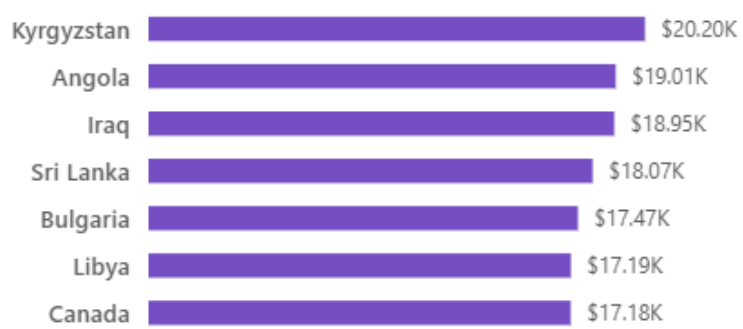
Total Sales
by Order Priority



Total Sales
by Sales Channel



Total Sales
by Country



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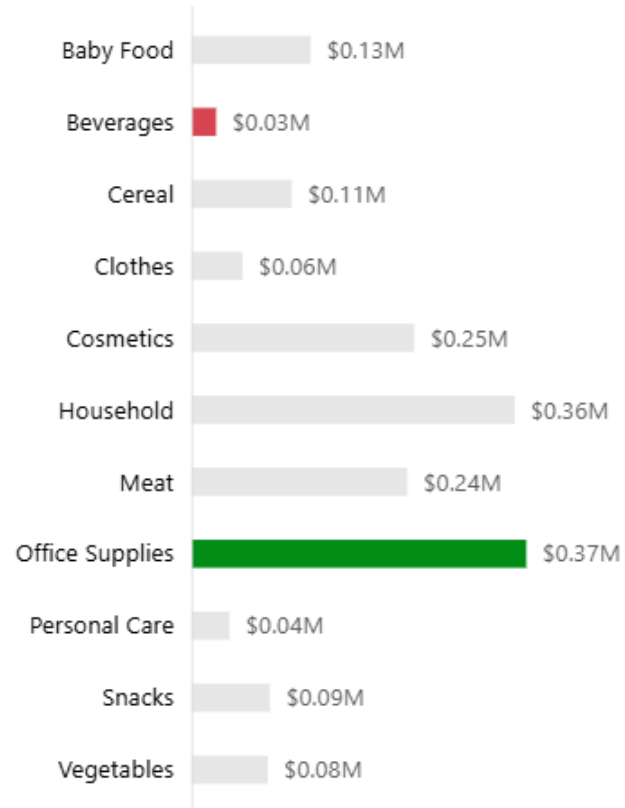
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$2.36M	$1.76M	43.989M	33M	$1.66M	$1.24M

Sales Trends & Insights

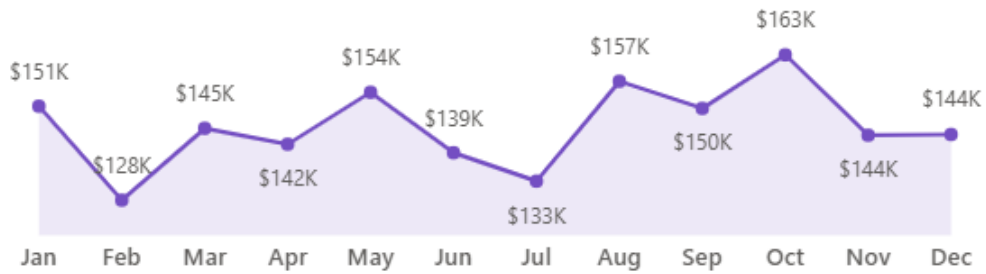
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Total Sales	Total Units	Total Cost	Total Orders
$1.75M	32.667M	$1.24M	6.508K
PY $1.74M ▲	PY 32.99M ▼	PY $1.22M ▼	PY 6.63K ▲

Total Sales
by Item Type

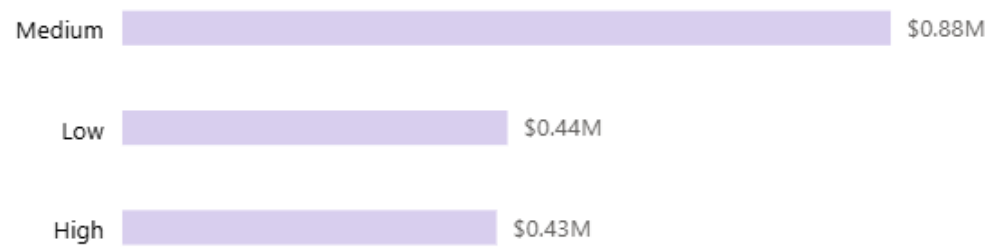


Total Sales
by Month



Total Sales
by Order Priority

Country | Order Priority | Sales Channel



Units Sold Summary

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Office Supplies	2.9M	
Personal Care	2.5M	
Snacks	2.8M	
Vegetables	2.7M	
Total	**32.7M**	

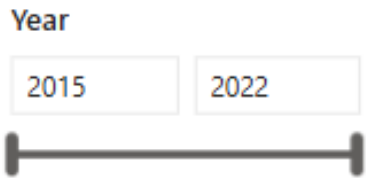
Hick’s Law

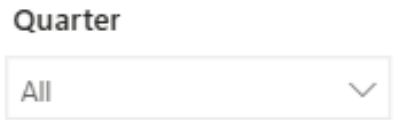
Techniques to Try

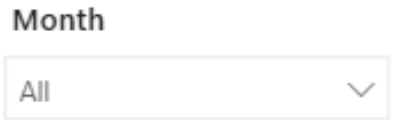
1. Show the most relevant choices first.
2. Group related filters & controls.
3. Reveal additional options when needed.(Progressive Disclosure)

Hick’s Law

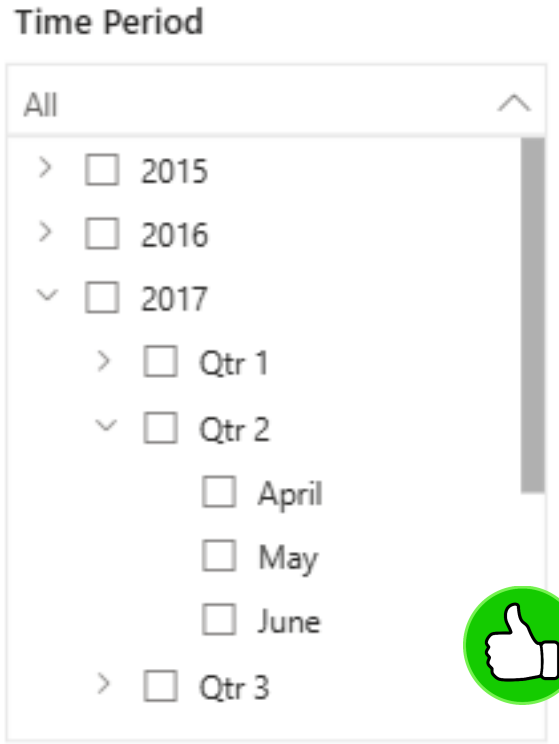
Group related filters & controls.









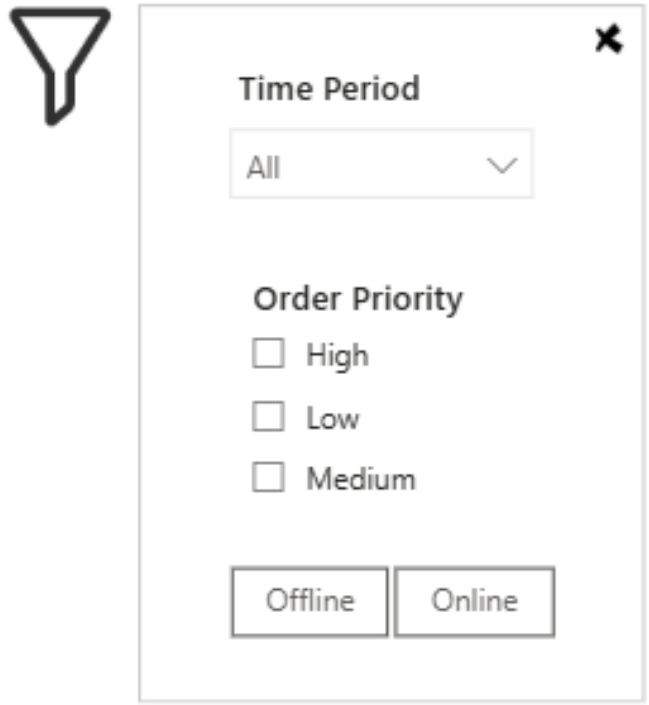




Hick’s Law

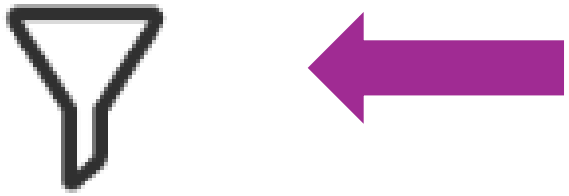
Progressive Disclosure

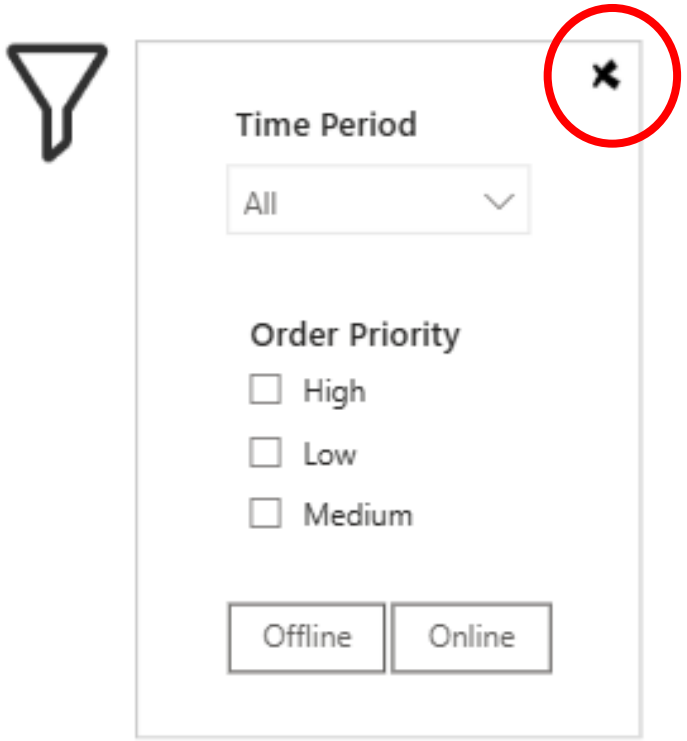




Hick's Law

Progressive Disclosure





Time to Pick

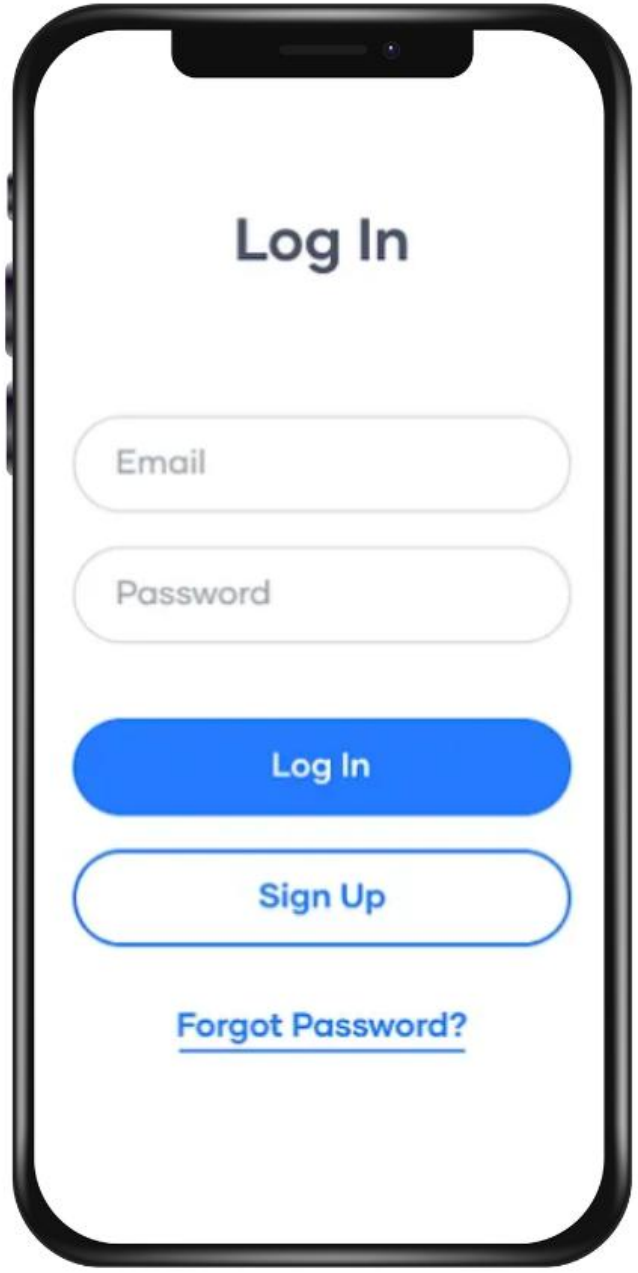


Time to Pick

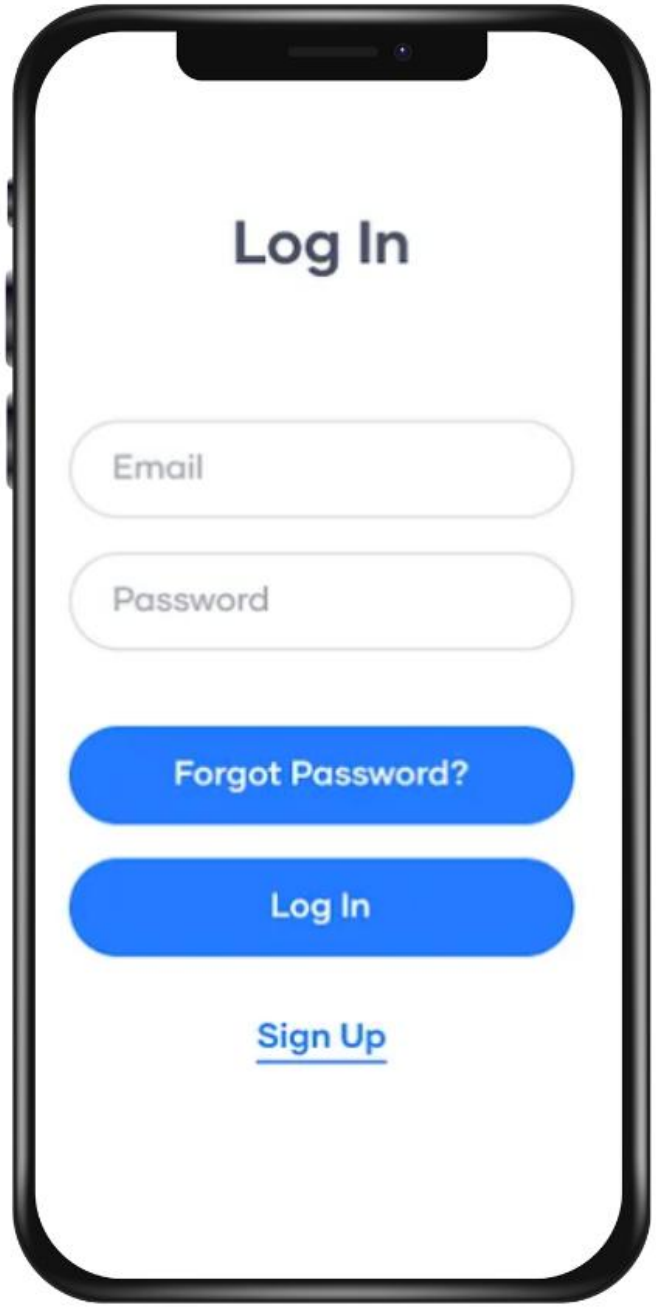
Which login interface would you find easier and comfortable to use?



1

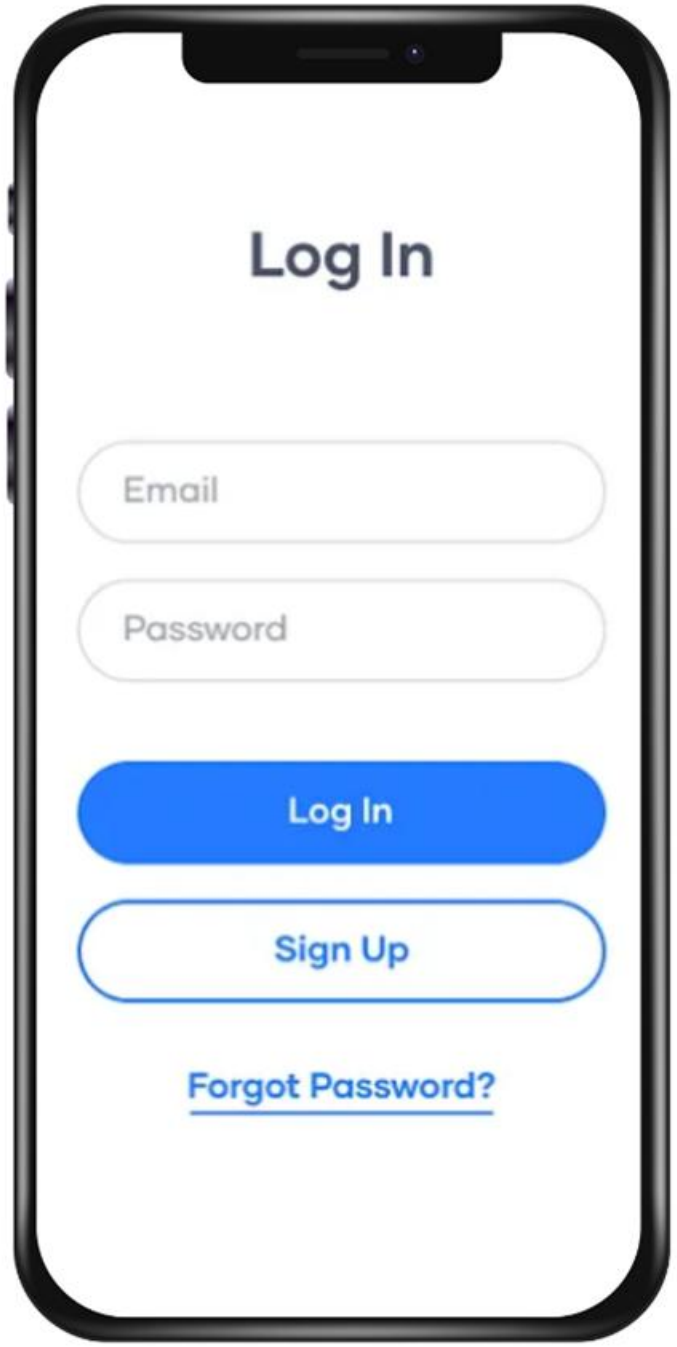


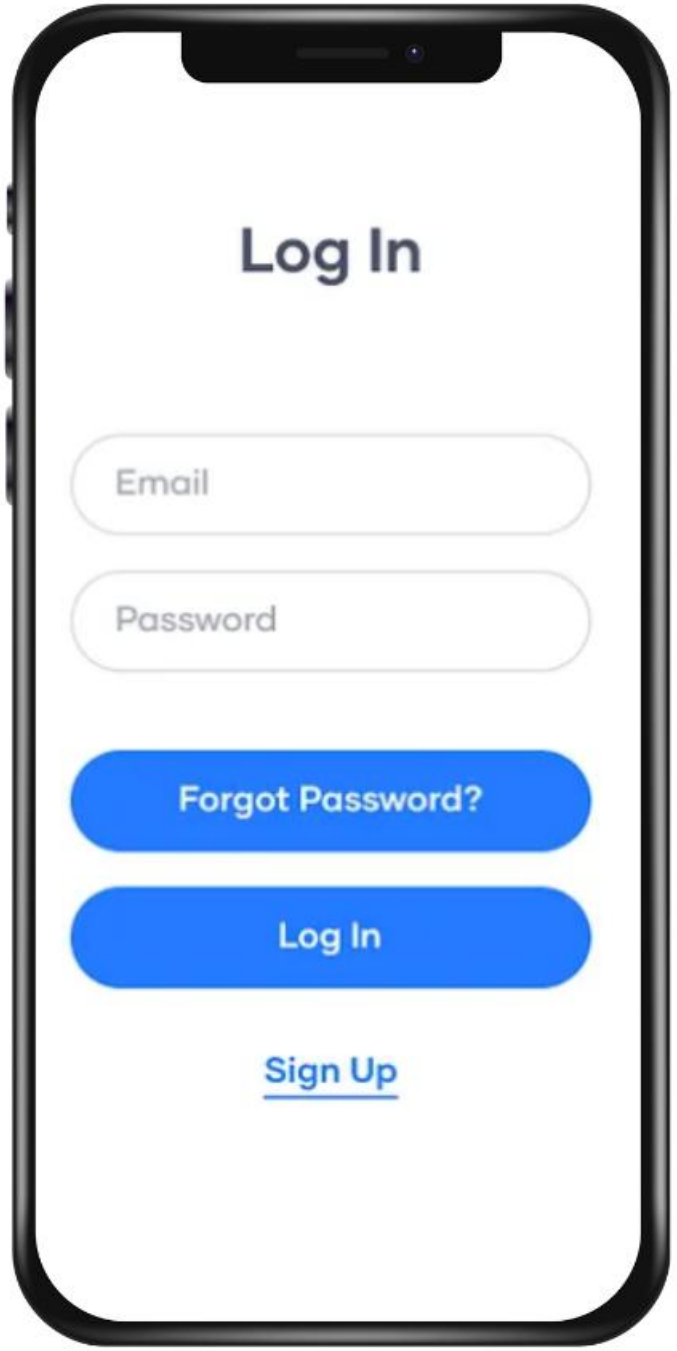
2



1




Log In
Email
Password
Log In
Sign Up
Forgot Password?


Log In
Email
Password
Forgot Password?
Log In
Sign Up

2

Jakob’s Law

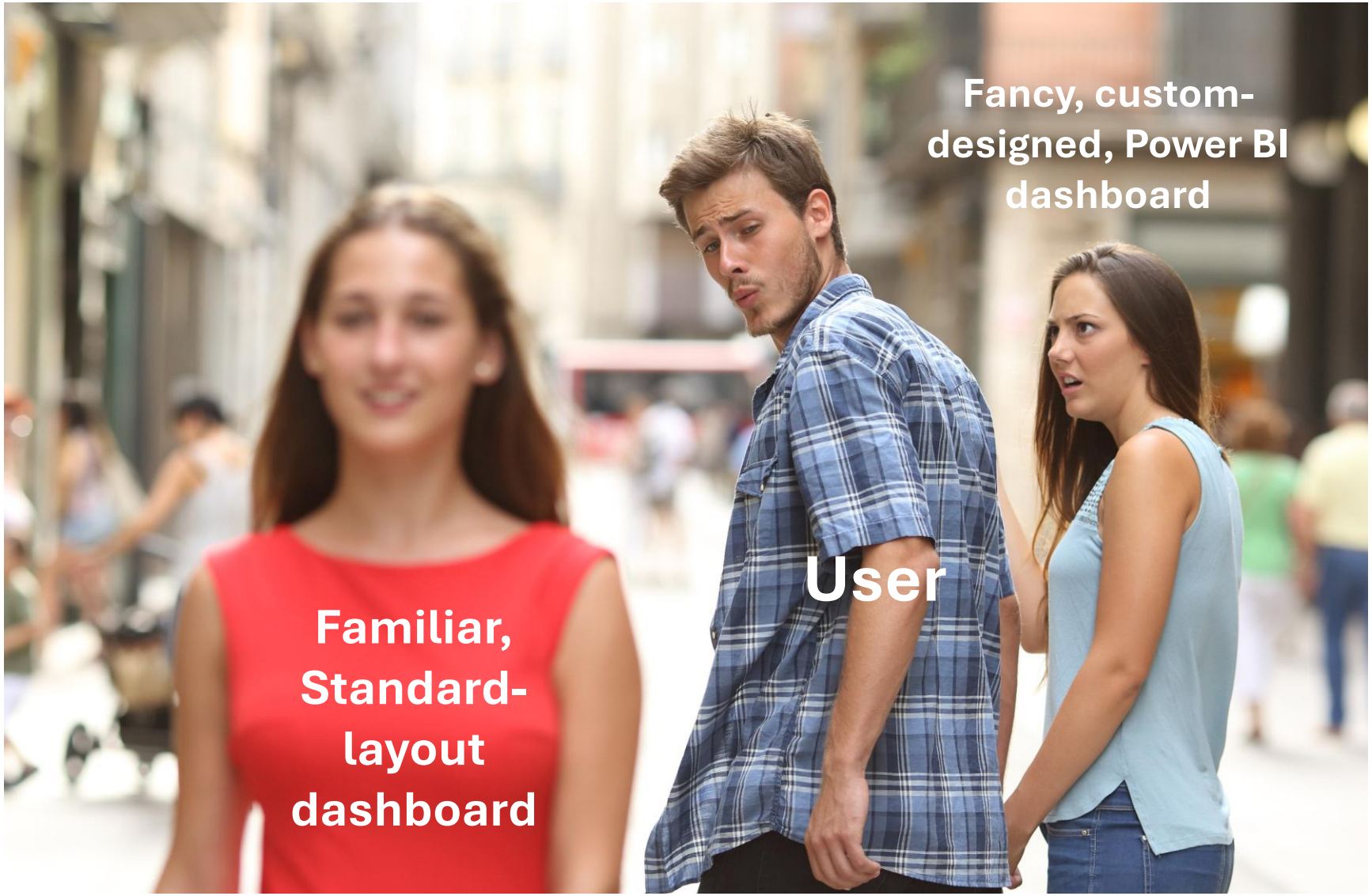


Jakob’s Law

People expect familiar things to **work in familiar ways**.



Jakob’s Law


Fancy, custom-designed, Power BI dashboard
User
Familiar, Standard-layout dashboard

Jakob’s Law

Why It Matters in Power BI?

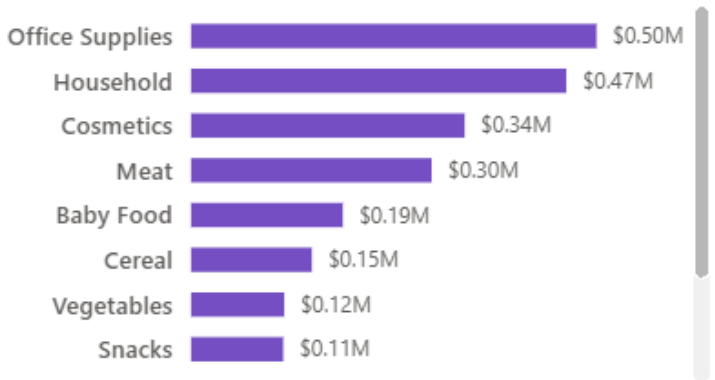
Your users arrive with expectations. Your report design should **look and behaves like tools they already use** (like Excel, websites, or mobile apps).

Make it easier for them to recognize what to do.

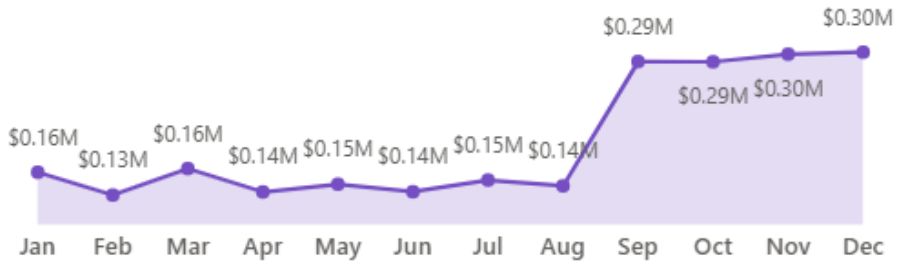
Year: 2020 | Quarter: All | Month: All | Order Priority: All | Sales Channel: All

Sales Trends

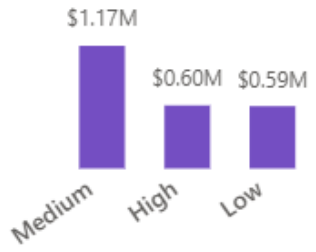
Total Sales
by Item Type



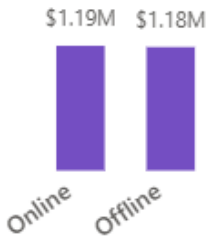
Total Sales
by Month



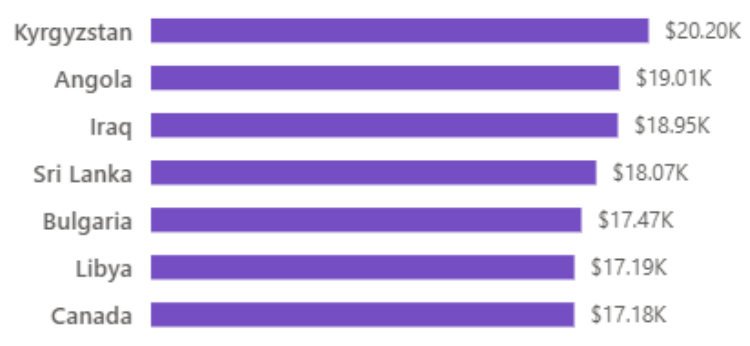
Total Sales
by Order Priority



Total Sales
by Sales Channel



Total Sales
by Country



Sales Summary

Item Type	Total Sales	Units Sold
Baby Food	$0.19M	3.6M
Beverages	$0.03M	3.5M
Cereal	$0.15M	3.7M
Clothes	$0.08M	3.7M
Cosmetics	$0.34M	3.9M
Fruits	$0.01M	3.6M
Household	$0.47M	3.4M
Meat	$0.30M	3.4M
Office Supplies	$0.50M	3.9M
Personal Care	$0.06M	3.6M
Snacks	$0.11M	3.7M
Vegetables	$0.12M	3.9M

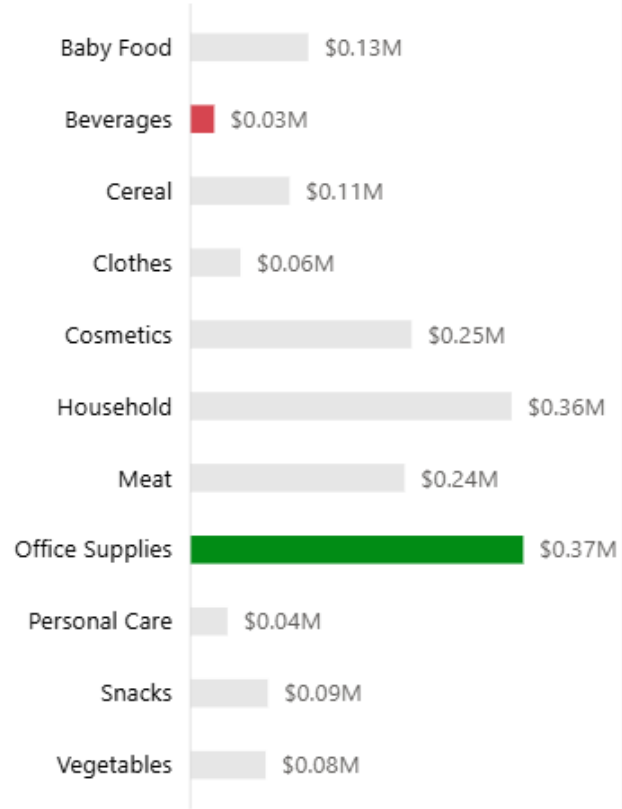
Total Sales	PY Sales	Total Units	PY Units	Total Cost	PY Cost
$2.36M	$1.76M	43.989M	33M	$1.66M	$1.24M

Sales Trends & Insights

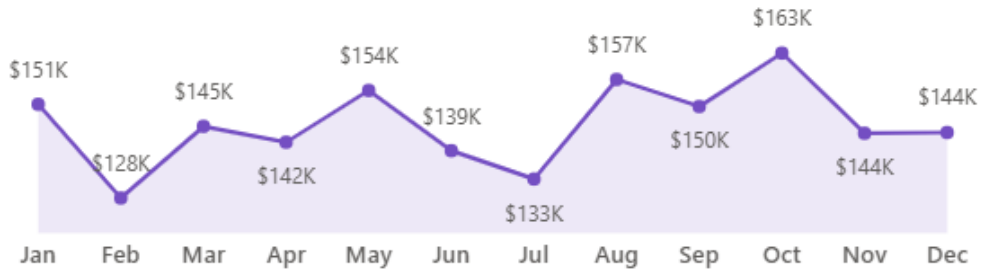
Year: 2014 | 2015 | 2016 | 2017 | **2018** | 2019 | 2020 | 2021 | 2022

Total Sales	Total Units	Total Cost	Total Orders
$1.75M	32.667M	$1.24M	6.508K
PY $1.74M ▲	PY 32.99M ▼	PY $1.22M ▼	PY 6.63K ▲

Total Sales
by Item Type

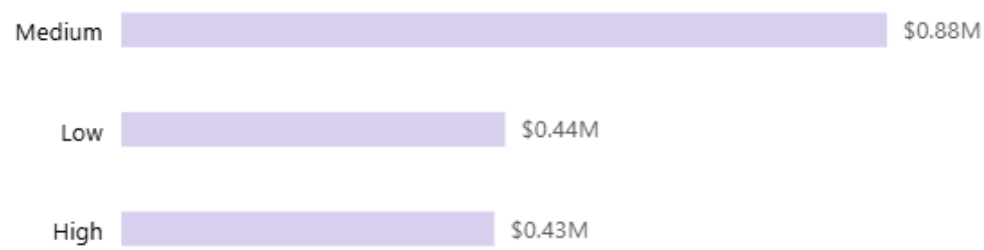


Total Sales
by Month



Total Sales
by Order Priority

Country | Order Priority | Sales Channel



Units Sold Summary

Item Type	Units Sold	Trend
Baby Food	2.6M	
Beverages	2.8M	
Cereal	2.8M	
Clothes	2.5M	
Cosmetics	2.7M	
Fruits	2.9M	
Household	2.7M	
Meat	2.8M	
Office Supplies	2.9M	
Personal Care	2.5M	
Snacks	2.8M	
Vegetables	2.7M	
Total	**32.7M**	

Jakob’s Law

Techniques to Try

1. Use familiar icons with clear labels.
2. Keep navigation and filters in consistent locations.
3. Check your design with actual users.

BONUS!



Gestalt principle of proximity



Gestalt principle of proximity

Elements that are close together are perceived as related or grouped- even if they’re not visually connected.

Proximity = connection.



Gestalt principle of proximity



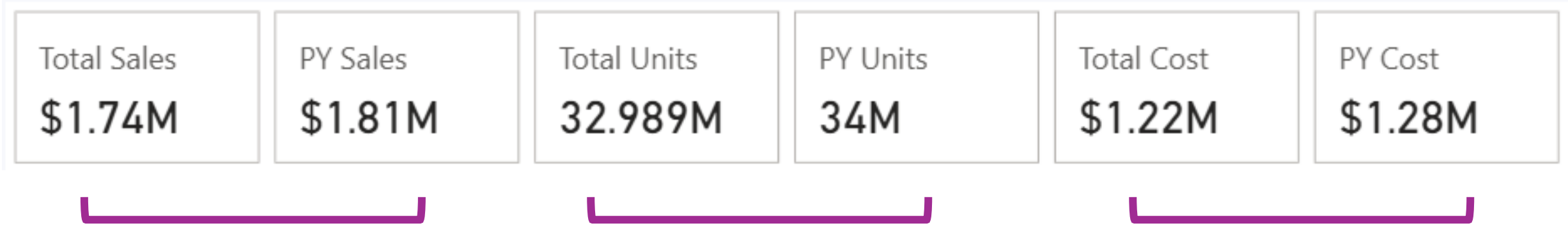
Gestalt principle of proximity

Why It Matters in Power BI?

When using dashboards, users scan quickly. They're not reading line by line. So if a KPI is far from its label → user may misinterpret it. If two unrelated visuals are close together → user assumes they're related.

Then your dashboard is sending mixed signals even if your data is perfect.

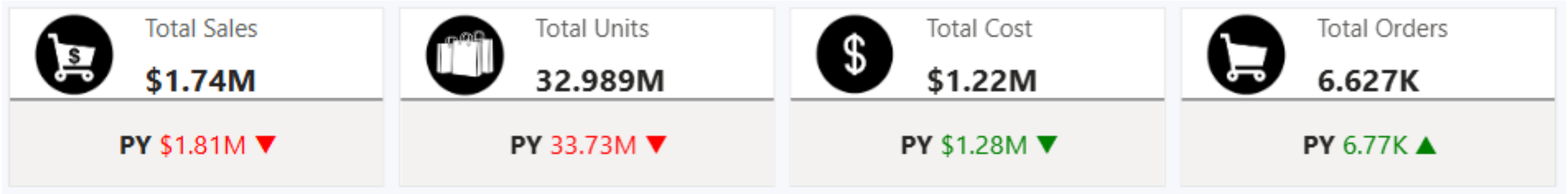
Gestalt principle of proximity



Gestalt principle of proximity

Total Sales	PY Sales	Total Units	PY Units	Total Cost	PY Cost
$1.74M	$1.81M	32.989M	34M	$1.22M	$1.28M





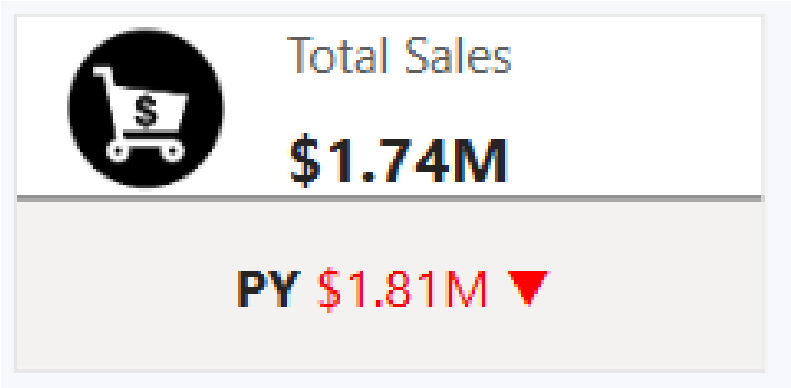
Gestalt principle of proximity

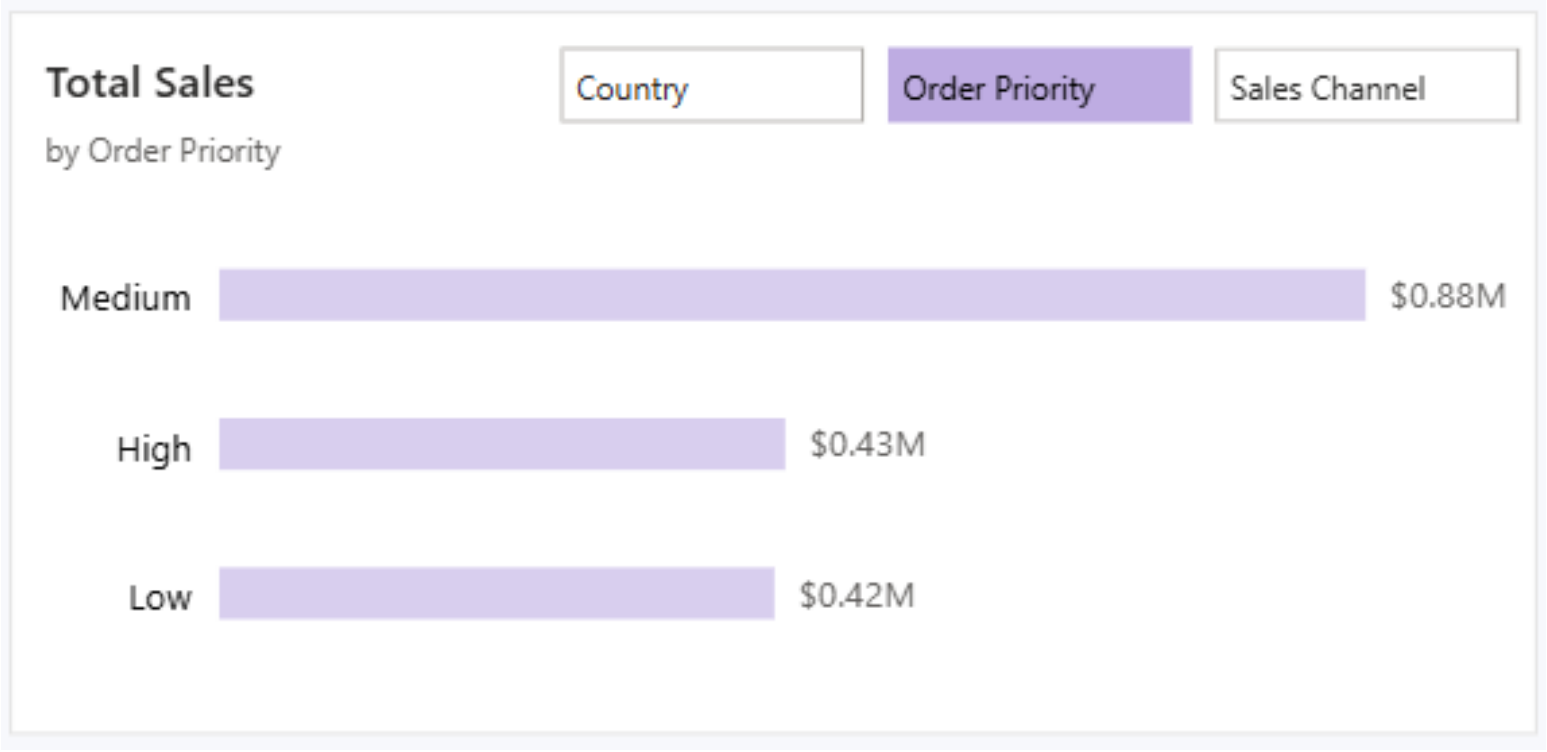
Techniques to Try

1. Place related metrics together.
2. Add whitespace between unrelated sections.
3. Keep labels close to the values they describe.
4. Use Visual Containers.

Gestalt principle of proximity

Use Visual Containers





Key Takeaways

01 | **Von Restorff Effect**
Highlight what matters.

02 | **Hick's Law**
Make choices easier to navigate.

03 | **Jakob's Law**
Use familiar patterns.

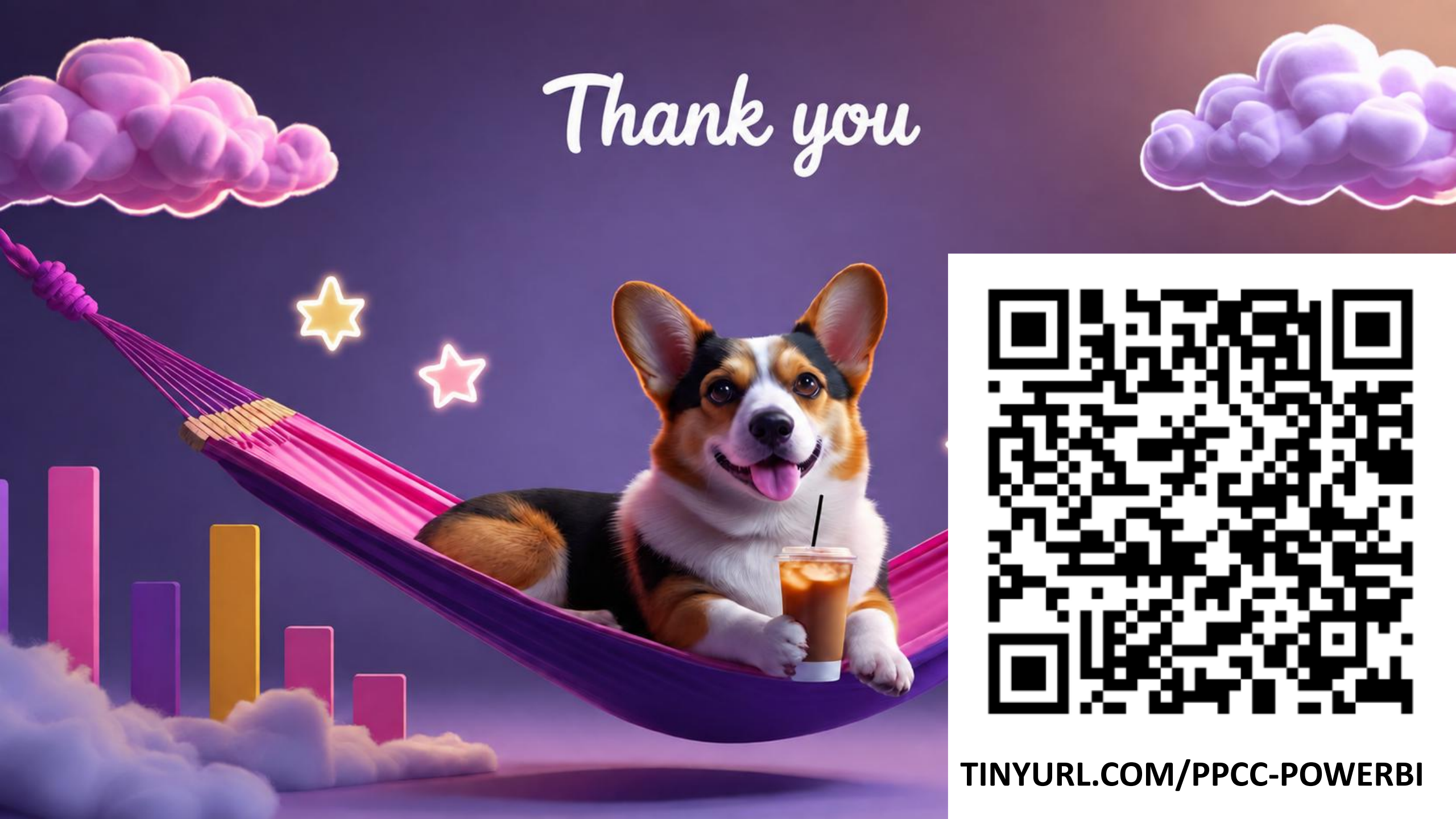
04 | **Proximity**
Place related information together.

When you go home….

Open one of your Reports and try these:

- [ ] Highlight one insight that matters
- [ ] Make the next step easy to find
- [ ] Use familiar, clear controls
- [ ] Place related information together





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